Love and Havok

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/43801912.

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Mature

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Graphic Depictions Of Violence

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Finn | Adora/Catra Child (She-Ra), Original Characters, Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra)

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Generational Trauma, Post-Traumatic Stress Disorder - PTSD, Trauma, Mental Health Issues, Forgiveness, Reincarnation, For the Love of Shadow Weaver Collection (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner's A+ Parenting, Soap Opera with Extra Steps, Drama & Romance, Family Drama, Dysfunctional Family, no beta we die like men, Adora Needs Therapy (She-Ra), please comment

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Love and Havok

by MaxxPhoenixV1

Summary

They say that the greatest trick the Devil had ever played was convincing the world she didn't exist.

It's 20 years since the end of the Great War of Etheria. A lot has happened in those 20 years.

-Meeting an alternate dimension version of Adora.
-Rescuing Queen Angella from the void.
-Discovering Adora's twin brother, Adam.
-The Creation of Liq'Ollem
-And Castaspella becoming a popstar for some reason...

But through it all, peace has been restored. However, the peace did not come without a price. The Great War has left many scars, be it physically, mentally or spiritually. Just when it seems like an equilibrium has been gained, Micah, in all of his wisdom decides to take a new student under his wing, Kazari (Pronounced KAH-Zur-EE). What Kazari doesn't know are secrets about herself. Secrets that has ramifications that'll send ripples through the past, present and future.

The New Generation


Love and Havok
The Rise of Kazari
Maxx Phoenix

Adora's Log #1...

20 years. It's been over 20 years since the defeat of Horde Prime. I can hardly believe so much time has passed. To me, it always felt like it was yesterday, what with the constant panic attacks and PTSD and whatnot. Then again, I try to remember everything that has happened. If I listed everything, I'd be here all day, but at the top of my head: I was made Grand Knight of Etheria, we discovered another dimension and met a different version of me (Sidenote- Retro Adora, as we've been calling her, is a bit of a weirdo. She can also become She-Ra, but she has a bizarre habit of announcing it to nobody in particular). We brought back Queen Angella, but it seems all those years in the void have caused some lasting damage to her psyche. Oh yeah, we also accidently resurrected the past She-Ras. Actually, my son, Finn, is at Liq'Ollem, training with Juliet right now. I wonder if-"

"Yo, Adora! You ready? We're gonna go check on Finn. Also, we have guest coming along"

Adora looked up at her wife, Catra. The magicat extended her hand, which Adora happily took.

Liq'Ollem

Even after 20 years, it was still hard to believe that this place used to be the Fright Zone, but what stood in its place was a sprawling metropolis, a melting pot of all the cultures of Etheria. Let's go to the park, where Finn was busy building muscles and training with Juliet. Training for the G1 Cosmic Tenkaichi.

Following Finn's birth, Juliet was made to be a godmother to the son of Adora and Catra, a task she has excelled in greatly. "That's right. That's how you do it!" Juliet proudly told Finn as they did the 200th set of reps! "Thanks. It's all your doing. I have a great trainer you know." Finn winks at Juliet who has been a mentor and guide ever since they were born. Juliet laughed heartily at

them. "Damn right! Hey, your moms are here!" she said, pointing to the stupid lesbian and her cat wife!"

Finn gave a sigh as they walked up to the moms. "Hey, Mamadora. Hey, Momoew. What are you guys doing here?" they asked.

Adora replied, "Well, We're here to see you, silly!"

Catra tried to ruffle Finn's hair, only for them to swat her hand away.

"Oh yeah," Adora perked up, "We brought along someone really special!"

Finn and Juiliet looked at each other, then back to the couple. "Oh, and who is this special guest?" Juliet asked.

Catra and Adora pointed to the approaching third woman.

"Finn, I want you to meet Retro Adora. She's not from our dimension! You both haven't been able to get to know each other and Finn, she happens to be your aunt. Might as well introduce yourself to your aunt, don't you think?"

Finn gave this a thought and then said, "I guess so. I would love to know her, Mom." Finn said and genuinely meant it. Retro Adora was a part of their family and it was incumbent upon Finn to know every member of their family. "Hello Finn, my gorgeous nephew. Can't believe I'm seeing you for the first time in twelve years! What a journey it's been, ha?" Retro Adora was always the chirpy one in the family and she would always make it a point to let everyone know that she is a She-Ra. She took a lot of pride in being a She-Ra and could not say it out loud enough, much to everyone's annoyance.

"Well then, I guess you will be seeing more of me, auntie. Rest assured," said Finn with a wink.

"I'm eagerly looking forward to it," replied Retro Adora.

With the recurrent trips she had made to this realm from the other dimension and functioning as an actual family member for Adora and Catra, she really had become a fixture in their life. "Alright, then. Off you go. Better not keep everyone waiting," said Adora. "Oh, yes. I have to go and check on the others. I'll join you all later then." Finn waved the three ladies a goodbye and headed off to check on the others.

"Bye, bitches!"

Squared off under a tree, Scorpia and her daughter, Rose, were found sparring with each other. Perfuma watched from a distance. Between the scorpion claws at the end of her fingertips and the flower power, Rose was truly the best of both worlds. Rose cartwheeled over a sweeping kick, and attempted a pele, only to be caught in Scorpia's grip.

"Dammit!" Rose shouted.

"Easy, Rose. You're gonna do great at the Cosmic Tenkaichi, but you still have a lot to learn!" Scorpia said with a grin.

"Looks like your training in going well," An approaching Finn remarked. "Of course, being the offspring of Scorpia and I has it's perks," said Pefuma.

"Rose is awesome! She's gonna do so well in the tournament," Scorpia gushed.

Finn placed an arm over Rose's shoulder. "They're right, y'know. I can't wait to see you in action" Finn said. Rose always felt good about herself, but it didn't hurt to let someone gas her up, however, she couldn't help but feel a small twinge of envy towards the young magicat. "Finn, when we get older, you'll be the first of us to get laid, won't ya?" she asked. "ROSE! YOU'RE 13! Don't be so vulgar!" Perfuma shouted before calming down.
"Sorry...sorry...but you really don't need to be so...perverse. Rose rolled her eyes calmly. Deep down, she knows that she's still in

the early stages of puberty, and eventually, her hormones would hit her like a ton of bricks.

"Right, imma go check up on Maila. The gods know she must be getting put through her paces!"

By the lake, the daughter of Seahawk and Mermista repelled fast flying water balls. Also, Frosta was there to chuck snowballs every once in a while.

"Let's go! Pep in your step!" Mermista demanded. After a bit more dodging and weaving, Maila closed in on Frosta, then wiped the sweat from the blue streak in her otherwise brown hair and shot it into the ice princess's eyes.

Frosta reeled back in pain. "Ow, you goddamned cheap-shotting little shit!" she said as she decked Maila in the face.

"Yo, Frosta! Got bored bodying scrubs in Smash, so you're bodying scrubs IRL?"

"Finn, shut the fuck up! I'm no scrub!" said Maila.

Finn rolled their eyes with a chuckle. "Good to see you too, Maila. How's training going?"

The mermaid-pirate princess gave a confident smirk. "I am so ready for a tourney. Finn, are YOU ready for a championship ADVENTURE?!!!" Mermista rubbed the bridge of her nose. "Uuugh, Maila, you don't have to yell, we're right here!" she moaned. Maila was definitely her and Seahawk's daughter, she had inherited Mermista's mermaid form, but that's all she got. Maila snickered like an idiot as Frosta suddenly got a message on her holo-pager. "Oh crap, speaking of tournaments, I got a local Smash tournament at Snow.

As soon as Frosta was out of earshot, Finn said, "I swear, I don't think she ever really grew up, did she? Speaking of adult-children, where's Seahawk?"

Mermista rolled her eyes. "Finn, remind Adora to swing be Sealinies later today. Seahawk is nursing a broken bussy..." she droned.

Maila tilted her head. "What's a bussy"

Finn turned a bright head, but then they noticed Riley. Riley sprinted around the trees and shrubbery as a laugh-filled Spinnerella stood on her tornado, which blasted tennis balls everywhere. Riley moved serpentine. High above him, Netossa swung from tree to tree with her nets. "Come on, Riley. Put some pep in your step, son!" said Netossa. At the moment, Finn ran up to Riley, running backwards, saying, "Well, looks like, Spinny and Netossa are putting you through it.

"Hey, Finn! Can't talk! Being pelted with balls!" said Riley.

"RILEY! PHRASING!" shouted Spinnerella.

"Sorry, Mom!"

Riley suddenly tripped over a loose branch, leaving him wide open to get blasted with several balls.

Finn awkwardly rubbed the back of their head, saying, "Oof, I'll just go check on Archer!"

Archer's training just amounted to being shot at by Glimmer and Micah as Bow and Angella sat on the sidelines, taking it all in. "Oh yeah, that's right, Archer. Dance, son. Dance!" Speaking of dancing, Glimmer's movements with new magic kinda looked like samba combat. "Come on, Mom. Come on, Grandpa Micah! Bring me all you got!

"Y'know, it's still surreal to have a grandson," Micah mused.

"Yes, well, he is a good one", Angella remarked. Ever since being rescued from the void, things were not easy for the bridlady. All those years in total, white isolation have wreaked havoc on

Angie's psyche, the road to recovery has been slow and painful, but she has made great strides, and Archer certainly helped out.

Glimmer's eyes sparkled as she grinned an almost crazed grin as she obliged. Teleporting into point blank range, Glimmer attempted to blast Archer in the face, but Archer diverted the shot, which nearly hit Finn, who was perched up in a nearby tree. Luckily, Finn had the wherewithal to dodge at the last moment.

"Glimmer, did you forget to take your meds again?" they pondered.

Angella raised an eyebrow.

"Meds? Glimmah, what're they talking about?!"

Glimmer desperately looked for excuses to get out of the situation. "Uh...Finn, you were on your way to see Iyexi. I'll teleport you to your buddy, Iyexi, since I need to talk to Entrapta!"

With that, Glimmer pounced and tackled Finn, teleporting them both to the other side of the park.

Hordak and Entrapta took notes as Iyexi threw precise and calculated punches and kicks at Kadroh, who was formerly known as Wrong Hordak. "Very good, sister!" said Kadroh. Iyexi lined up a strong kick, only for Glimmer to teleport into the line of fire and get the wind knocked outta her!

"Are you okay?" said Iyexi.

Glimmer struggled to her feet and said, "Yeah, I'm all good, but y'know, I still can't believe you two had a kid. I didn't think Hordak had a dick!"

Finn rolled their eyes as they went to go speak with Iyexi and Kodroh. "Finn, brother! How are your mothers?" said Kadroh.

"Well, Mamadora hasn't had a manic episode in a couple months, a new record, so I'd say we're doing fine..."

Iyexi took Finn by the hand. "Finn! Are you ready for that tournament? Ready to go in and bust some heads?"

Finn chuckled.

"Hell yeah. We're going all the way!"

Iyexi chuckled. "Let's save it for the tournament. Speaking of which, it's gonna be on Xisaeus, so we'd better be careful with the wildlife, y'know!"

"Yeah, whatever, Iyexi."

"Hey, Finn. Isn't your cousin, Rohan, competing this year?"

Finn nodded. "Yep, he is. We've made a pact that we'd face each other in the finals!"

While the two were having their discussion, Glimmer went up to Entrapta, saying, "So, have you finished with your little project yet?"

Entrapta beamed, telling the queen, "Yep! I've finally managed to mod us all into Smash!"

"Excellent! This is gonna be lit!"

Meanwhile, Iyexi produced a tablet to show Finn the current tournament bracket.

"Alright, so there is one competitor, from Xisaeus. Her name is Kazari, so I guess she'll have a hometown advantage. Finn? FIIINN? FINN!!!" Iyexi shouted.

Finn was suddenly jolted back to reality.

"Shit...I'm sorry, it's just Kazari...she's a magicat! Just like me and Momeow. So rare!" they said.

Planet Xisaeus. The Next Day

The hot sun bared down on a certain magicat. She sported dark red hair with a matching tail wrapped around her waist like a belt, gray fur and wore a tight red vest. Enter: Kazari.

As Kazari laid motionless, her dads, Ian Artemy and Steve Pigeon walked up to her, with Artemy saying, "Oi, Kazari, if you're not too busy, we're gonna need you to make a snag run."

Kazari yawned and kipped up. "Fuckin' hell, dads. I was having the best nap. Alright then, I'll be back.

As Kazari went into the city, she took a look at the massive stadium in the center of the city square. With a smirk, she simply said, "Look out, world, here comes Kazari!"

Chapter 2- Cosmic Tenkaichi

The day of the G1 Cosmic Tenkaichi dawned upon Brightmoon, gathering everyone as per Juliet's request. Finn broke the silence, unable to contain their curiosity. "So, Juliet, what's the big deal? Why did you summon us all here?" Juliet and Adora exchanged knowing smiles before Adora spoke up. "We've got some important matters to discuss, folks. First off, our team needs a name. And since we're proudly representing both Etheria and Eternia, we shall be known as... Team Grayskull!"

In response, Glimmer conjured a box, revealing a collection of jackets adorned with a fierce fanged lightning bolt emblem. "Damn, these jackets are seriously awesome!" exclaimed Iyexi. Angella rolled her eyes and chimed in, "I swear, the slang of your generation is beyond me, Iyexi."

Micah, seeking to comfort Angella, interjected, "You know, it's quite peculiar how close the son of She-Ra and the daughter of Hordak have become."

Meanwhile, Juliet was busy inspecting the bracket on her tracker pad when Catra approached her abruptly. "Hey, Juliet, let me see that bracket!" demanded the magicat, lacking any manners.

Juliet obliged, turning the tablet towards Catra, who was taken aback by what she saw. On the bracket, there was a gray magicat bearing short red hair and piercing green feline eyes.

"Her name's Kazari, and it seems she's running solo," Juliet revealed.

"Gods above, the resemblance is uncanny! But nah, it couldn't be..." Catra muttered, her disbelief evident.

Juliet, noticing the exchange, inquired, "Is there a problem?"

Before the conversation could delve deeper, Catra was struck by a fit of coughing, though fortunately, no hairballs were expelled this

time. Falling to her knees, Catra found herself joined by Adora, concern etched across her face. "Don't worry, Adora. I'm fine," Catra assured her, rising to her feet.

Just then, Finn burst into the room, interrupting the tense moment. "Moms, is everything okay? It's time to head out for the tournament!" they announced.

Adora nodded in affirmation. "Right, go warm up Darla!"

Finn acknowledged the command and hurried off to prepare Darla, their anticipation mounting.

About an hour later...

Glimmer gazed out of the bay window, her voice filled with determination. "Alright, everyone. We're just a couple of minutes away. I have one final piece of advice for you all: FIGHT HARD! HAVE FUN! KEEP YOUR EYES CLEAR AND YOUR HEARTS FULL! AND REMEMBER, WE CAN'T LOSE!" Bow placed a calming hand on Glimmer's shoulder. "Take it easy, Glimmer," he reassured her. Finn's voice cut through the tension. "We've arrived!" they announced.

Team Grayskull rushed to the windows, their eyes widening as they took in the sight before them. The stadium stood vast and vibrant, with seats filling up quickly. At one end, a massive stage reminiscent of a grand concert awaited, its ramp stretching all the way down to the ring. On the canvas, a yin-yang symbol was prominently displayed.

As Darla touched down, Adora led the way, followed closely by the rest of the team. "Come on, Finn. Let's find Rohan!"

"Hey, Finn! Aunt Adora!" a voice called out.

"Well, looks like we won't have to search for long," Adora remarked.

A boy around Finn's age stood just a few feet away. He sported a lavender headband that held back his long red hair, a trait inherited from his mother, Teela. Not far behind him were King Adam and Queen Teela.

Adora, despite her changes over the years, retained her jock-like demeanor and lack of grace. Spotting Adam, she couldn't contain her enthusiasm. "ADAM!" she exclaimed, launching herself at her brother and planting a wet, sloppy kiss on his cheek. Teela and Catra swiftly intervened, pulling Adora away. Adam simply chuckled and said, "Good to see you too, Adora."

Rohan raised an eyebrow. "Mom, Dad seems to be taking that quite well," he commented. Teela rolled her eyes. "Not surprised. Adora once proclaimed, in front of gods and everyone, that apart from Bow, Adam was the only man she'd go straight for..."

Retro Adora approached the twins, breaking the moment. "As much as I hate to interrupt this lovely reunion, we should probably head to the locker room."

"Hey, other Adora," Adam greeted.

Retro Adora nodded in greeting just as three women approached the trio of warriors. "Wow, you're She-Ra, He-Man, and the other She-Ra!" one of them exclaimed.

"We're like your biggest fans! Will you sign our... uh, autographs?" The three women simultaneously lifted their shirts, revealing an array of ample bosoms in various shapes and sizes. Adam gasped, while Adora, true to her jock-like nature, spewed a spray of blood in surprise. Retro Adora maintained her composure slightly better, but being an Adora herself, she couldn't help but drool like a dog on a scorching summer day as she signed her name, remarking, "I just love being me!"

In the locker room...

Kazari paced back and forth, her nerves getting the best of her. Artemy and Pigeon tried to offer some comfort. "Take a deep

breath, Kazari. You'll exhaust yourself before your first match," Artemy advised.

"Yeah, try to relax and have fun out there," Pigeon added.

Kazari nodded, taking their words to heart. Just then, Team Grayskull entered the locker room. While Kazari was briefly distracted, Adora and Catra stole glances at the magicat. However, Finn approached Kazari, breaking the silence.

"Hey, I'm Finn. She-Ra's offspring. Good luck out there," they said, extending a hand.

"Thanks, Finn. If you make it to the finals, I'd be honored to take you on!" Kazari replied, winking playfully.

Before the conversation could progress further, Adora swiftly pulled Finn away, leaving Kazari confused.

"All competitors, please report to the main stage for the opening ceremony!"

The Main Stage...

All the tournament teams stood on their pedestals, each adorned with their respective logos. The announcer took hold of the microphone, gesturing toward the teams. "Welcome, one and all, to the 8th Annual G1 Cosmic Tenkaichi. Let's give a warm welcome to the teams who will be battling for supremacy!" The Princess Alliance had secured seats in the skybox as the teams were introduced one by one.

"Representing Planet Zachin, it's Team Junga!"

"From Planet Cimexxo, give it up for Team Thunderstruck!"

"Making their presence known from Planet Panjax, let's hear it for Team Gingas!"

"Representing Planet Sahars, put your hands together for Team Corona!"

"From Planet Shuddah, it's Team Express!"

"Hailing from Planet Santhex, give a round of applause for Team Thenia!"

"Coming straight from Planet Primus, let's welcome Team XeXalla!"

"And representing both Etheria and Eternia, give a thunderous roar for Team Grayskull!"

Team Grayskull waved to the excited crowd, Finn chiming in, "Wow, they're really into us. Let's put on a show, everyone!"

"And lastly, fighting unaffiliated, all the way from our very own Planet Xisaeus, it's Kazari!"

If the uproar from the crowd was any indication, Kazari being the hometown fighter had surely stirred their enthusiasm.

"While the teams prepare, please enjoy the opening ceremony!"

Adora let out a sigh, retrieving her tablet. As she glanced at the match card, one particular pairing struck her to the core.

Round 1, Match 1:

Team Grayskull's

ARCHER (He/Him)

vs.

Kazari (She/They)

It was time for the first match of the tournament.

Archer burst onto the stage, absorbing the sight of the massive crowd before him, exuding confidence inherited from his mother, Glimmer. Adora held Catra's hand as Archer struck a pose, triggering alternating bursts of pyrotechnics from either side of the stage. Adora tensed at the sudden explosions, but Bow and Glimmer offered a reassuring squeeze. "It's alright, Adora. It's just pyro," Bow reassured her. Adora managed to calm down, with Bow and Glimmer cheering on their son as he made his way down the ramp.

Now in the ring, it was Kazari's turn to make her entrance.

Kazari exuded even more energy as the thirteen-year-old magicat jogged back and forth on the stage before

heading down the ramp. Midway, she stopped and locked eyes with Archer, striking a pose that unleashed a massive stream of pyrotechnics.

Micah glanced at Catra and Adora, voicing his thoughts. "There's something... off about that kid. I can't quite put my finger on it."

"I don't know, but the resemblance is uncanny. We'll have to keep an eye on her," Catra responded. Adora remained silent, her gaze fixed on Kazari as she entered the ring. The ring announcer grabbed the microphone.

"Ladies, gentlemen, and non-binary individuals, this match is scheduled for one fall. Introducing first, representing Team Grayskull... Archer! And their opponent, fighting unaffiliated, Kazari!"

After a brief pause, the bell rang, signaling the start of the match. Archer swiftly teleported behind Kazari, aiming a punch at her back, but Kazari landed on her hand and countered with a mule kick. Archer teleported out of harm's way just in time.

Now standing face to face, Archer wore a smug grin while Kazari seemed unfazed. "Alright, Archer," Kazari said, a hint of

excitement in her voice. "I'm glad we're paired up. I need the opportunity to practice these powers!"

Archer appeared perplexed. "Powers? What powers?" he inquired. His question was soon answered as Kazari's fist glowed with a dull green and purple aura. Before Archer could react, he found himself on the receiving end of a powerful uppercut, knocking him out cold. Kazari swiftly pinned his shoulders to the mat, and the referee began the count. "1... 2... 3!"

"With that, Kazari secures her first win of the day. Let's see if Team Grayskull can bounce back against Team Junga!"

Glimmer clenched her teeth in frustration, but Bow offered a comforting squeeze. "It's alright, Glimmer. Our son is much stronger than that. Right now, he needs our support."

In the infirmary...

Archer sat with an ice pack pressed against his head, surrounded by Finn and the Best Friend Squad. Bow offered reassurance, saying, "Don't worry, Archer. You did a great job!"

Finn chimed in, determined and confident. "Yeah, we'll get the win in our next match. We've got this!"

Adora kept her distance, lost in thought. The energy she felt from Kazari earlier... it reminded her of Havok. She couldn't shake off the unsettling feeling.

Next Match: Team Grayskull's Finn (They/Them) vs. Team Junga's Cymbol (He/Him)

While Cymbol was already in the ring, Finn walked confidently toward the ring, limbering up as they made their way down the ramp. Catra shouted, "You've got this, Finn!" Juliet reflected, "This is it, Finn. Time to show them what it means to be the child of a She-Ra. Make us proud."

Finn and Cymbol bowed to the referee and then to each other. As they retreated to their corners, the referee signaled for the bell. Finn swiftly lunged forward, dodging an extendo arm attack from Cymbol and delivering a powerful blow to his face, knocking him out immediately. Finn prepared for another attack, but the referee intervened, calling for medical attention for their opponent.

"Ladies and gentlemen, Cymbol is unable to continue. Therefore, the winner by knockout is Finn," the referee announced.

"Wow! What a turnaround! Finn secures the victory with a knockout. We'll take a short break, but we'll be right back with more action!"

In the locker room...

Kazari watched the monitor in awe of Finn's display of power. "Wow, Finn is going to be tough to beat. I hope I can keep up," she remarked.

UP NEXT:

Team Grayskull's Finn (They/Them) vs. Team Thenia's Shrumo (He/Him)

While Shrumo was already in the ring, Finn walked slowly toward the ring, determined to make Shrumo acknowledge them and Team Grayskull. They knew it wouldn't be an easy match. Shrumo was much bigger, but Finn, as the product of She-Ra's lineage, wouldn't go down without a fight. They were ready to show the world the sheer power of being She-Ra's child and Juliet's student.

"Let's go, Finn! You've got this!" Adora cheered. Finn climbed up the top rope and pointed toward Adora and Catra. The crowd joined in with a loud cheer, showing their support. Finn locked eyes with their opponent as the referee rang the bell.

Finn swiftly rushed in for an attack, but Shrumo countered with a series of German suplexes followed by devastating slams. Although these attacks landed, Finn hardly showed any signs of

damage. They quickly got up and delivered a powerful kick to Shrumo's face, sending him to his hands and knees. Seizing the opportunity, Finn climbed the top rope and performed a curb stomp, finishing off their opponent. Finn pinned Shrumo as the referee began the count: "1... 2... 3..."

"The winner of this match... Finn!"

Finn raised their hands in victory, and Adora and Catra couldn't be prouder.

Later on...

Maila displayed her impressive skills in the ring, circling around her opponent from Team Xexalla. In the skybox, Seahawk cheered enthusiastically, while Mermista maintained a more reserved demeanor.

With a well-executed hook to her opponent's inner thigh, Maila rolled through and transitioned into a superkick, securing the win.

Next Match: Team Grayskull's Iyexi (She/Her) vs. Team Corona's Bret (He/Him)

It was now Iyexi's turn to fight, and this match held great significance. A win for Iyexi would propel Team Grayskull to the semifinals. Her opponent from Team Corona, Bret, appeared stoic and formidable. Despite the challenge, the 13-year-old half-spacebat was fearless. Iyexi relied on her understanding of basic math and geometry to devise her strategy. As the bell rang, Bret charged at Iyexi, but she skillfully used his momentum to slam him into the turnbuckle. Seizing the opportunity, Iyexi executed a devastating bridging suplex, nearly securing the victory with a close 2 count. However, Iyexi had planned for this scenario. Springing to her feet, she swiftly caught Bret with a roundhouse kick to the head. Demonstrating irony, as the middle rope was known in some communities as "Bret's Rope," Iyexi finished off Bret with a split-legged moonsault from Bret's Rope, sealing her win.

UP NEXT:

Kazari, Unaffiliated (She/They) vs. Team Express' Jack (He/They)

Kazari found herself in a similar situation to Iyexi, needing to win this match to secure a spot in the semifinals. Jack, representing Team Express, proved to be faster than Kazari had anticipated, landing several elbows and forearms. Eventually, Kazari was forced back into a corner. Determined, she gritted her teeth and prepared to turn the tide. Jack moved in to finish her off, but Kazari swiftly retaliated with a Havok-infused knee strike to Jack's forehead. The impact reverberated throughout the stadium, creating an explosive sound. Catra turned to Adora, expressing her unease. "I'm getting some serious bad vibes from that Kazari girl," she said. Adora nodded in agreement, observing Kazari with a thoughtful gaze before being brought back to the present by the others.

"Mama mia! What a knockout victory! Kazari advances to the semifinals!"

The crowd erupted in wild excitement, cheering for the hometown underdog. However, the young magicat gingerly made her way out of the ring, clearly favoring a noticeable limp.

Later on...

UP NEXT

Team Grayskull's Riley (He/Him) vs. Team Gingas' Leosh

Back in the skybox, Adora glanced at Spinnerella and Netossa, a mixture of excitement and nervousness in her eyes. "Riley's up next. How are you feeling about it?" she asked. Spinnerella let out a sigh, her worry evident. "Excited, but nervous. I can't shake off this fear that Riley might get hurt," she admitted. Netossa squeezed Spinnerella's hand reassuringly. "We've trained him well, Spinny. Our son is capable, and he'll do just fine," she reassured.

Spinnerella managed a small smile, appreciating the support, though her nerves still lingered.

Meanwhile, in the locker room, Kazari sat on the bench, her knee throbbing with pain. She winced as doctors examined it, hoping for a glimmer of good news. "Tell it to me straight, doc. How bad is it?" she asked, trying to brace herself. The doctor let out a concerned sigh. "I'm not entirely sure. With some ice, a knee brace, and an Advil, you might make it through the semi-finals, but going further than that might be a challenge," he explained. Kazari's gaze fell upon a monitor displaying the ongoing matches.

"And with that, Riley scores another victory for Team Grayskull!"

Back in the skybox, Netossa wrapped an arm around Spinnerella's waist, offering comfort. "See, I told you there was nothing to worry about," she said, a hint of triumph in her voice. Adora, however, couldn't shake off her unease as she watched the next match commence. Juliet approached Adora, noticing her troubled expression. "Take it easy, Adora. Is it that Kazari girl that's bothering you?" she asked, trying to piece it together. Adora let out a sigh, her concerns palpable. "There's just something off about her. Her movements are different, more defensive. I need to pay close attention," she admitted.

Juliet attempted to ease Adora's worries. "Let's not jump to conclusions, Adora. We don't have the full picture. It could just be some random magicat," she suggested. Adora's glare towards Juliet showed her frustration. "How can you be so calm about this?" she retorted, her anxiety getting the better of her. Juliet maintained her composure, trying to reason with Adora. "I'm not calm, Adora. I'm just saying we shouldn't make hasty judgments," she explained, hoping to soothe Adora's concerns.

Some time later...

"It has been an epic and action-packed semi-final round of the G1 Cosmic Tenkaichi. We're just one match away from the finals. Who will join Finn in the main event?!"

Adora tensed up once more as vibrant towers of fireworks shot into the sky, illuminating the arena with a dazzling display. Catra took Adora's hand, offering solace. "It's okay, Adora. It's just the fireworks," she whispered, her touch providing a sense of calm. As the fireworks subsided, the next match was announced without delay.

UP NEXT

Team Grayskull's Iyexi (She/Her) vs. Kazari (She/They)

Iyexi knelt at the top of the stage, gathering her focus before springing to her feet and striding purposefully towards the ring. Hordak and Entrapta couldn't make it, so they had everyone wear welding goggles to show their support for Iyexi. Adora turned to Retro Adora, sharing her excitement. "Imagine if we win both the Overall and Grand championships. It'll be a testament to this new generation," she remarked. Retro Adora nodded in agreement, acknowledging the significance of such an achievement.

As Kazari made her entrance, Catra leaned in close to Adora's ear. "I need to use the restroom. I'll be back as quickly as I can," she whispered, assuring Adora of her prompt return. Adora's gaze remained fixated on Kazari, analyzing her movements with an intense focus. "Hmm, something's different about Kazari. Her stance, her demeanor. She seems more defensive," Adora observed. Catra nodded, her eyes mirroring Adora's concern.

Iyexi and Kazari circled each other in the ring, ready to clash. Adora's attention honed in on Kazari's stance, a sense of realization dawning upon her. "Kazari's stance has changed. Her left knee is dragging, and her right knee is in a support position. Almost as if..." she trailed off, interrupted by Catra's return.

"Hey, Adora. I'm back!"

Adora turned to Catra, relief washing over her as she saw her beloved wife. However, she couldn't ignore Catra's pallor and slight sweat. "Catra, you don't look well," Adora noted with

concern. Catra brushed it off, assuring Adora. "I'm okay, just a cough. So, what did I miss?" she asked, trying to catch up.

"Not much, the match just started."

Iyexi wasted no time, launching a swift kick towards Kazari's knee, which Kazari had to block with her hand, wincing in pain. Adora's gaze shifted to Catra, urgency in her voice. "Look, Kazari is already on the defensive. She must be hurt," she remarked. Catra nodded, her worry aligning with Adora's assessment.

Iyexi, too, recognized Kazari's injury, capitalizing on it by going for her bad knee with a pounce attack. Kazari utilized Iyexi's lowered center of gravity, executing a cartwheel to evade the blow, ensuring she landed on her good leg. But the respite was short-lived as Iyexi grabbed Kazari in a belly-to-belly overhead suplex, causing her to land painfully on her injured leg. A hiss of pain escaped Kazari's lips as Iyexi advanced, ready to strike. However, Kazari rolled back, pivoted onto her hand, and delivered a mule kick to Iyexi's jaw.

Using the ropes for support, Kazari pushed herself up, determination etched on her face.

"IYEXI! YOU HAVE TO FINISH THIS RIGHT NOW!!! DO IT!!!" Adora's voice boomed with a mix of encouragement and urgency.

Iyexi prepared to deliver the final blow, stepping back to line up a decisive strike. But Kazari didn't back down. As Iyexi gathered momentum, Kazari raised her bad knee, spreading her arms at a 45-degree angle. With all the speed and power she could muster, Iyexi lunged forward, only to meet Kazari's ROUNDHOUSE CRANE KICK head-on. The impact sent Iyexi crashing to the ground with a resounding thud. Kazari stumbled slightly, then went in for the pin.

"1...2...3!"

"Can you believe it?! After a topsy-turvy match, the main event is now set! Here is the final matchup:

MAIN EVENT

TEAM GRAYSKULL'S FINN (They/Them) vs. KAZARI, UNAFFILIATED (She/They)

Chapter 3- MAIN EVENT! Finn vs Kazari

With a determined look on her face, Adora turned to Glimmer and through gritted teeth, she uttered, "Glimmer, get us to the locker room. I need to talk to Finn!" Glimmer reluctantly acquiesced, sensing the urgency in Adora's voice.

The intermission before the main event was a moment of respite for Kazari. She thought to herself, "Just one more match. One more match, and I'll become the champion."

Meanwhile, Finn was stretching their limbs, ensuring they were as agile as possible for the crucial final battle. Suddenly, their attention was caught by the sound of Glimmer's teleportation. Adora called out to Finn, "Finn? Can I have a minute?" Curiosity piqued, Finn walked over to their mother. "I'm all ears," they said. Adora placed a firm hand on her son's shoulder and spoke with sternness in her voice. "Listen, Finn. Against any other opponent, I wouldn't care whether you win or lose, as long as you give it your all. But against this Kazari girl... something feels off... YOU MUST WIN! I implore you, do not lose! Do you understand?" Finn simply nodded, their determination fueled by Adora's words.

"Good. Catra, Bow, Glimmer, and I will be in the front row, cheering you on!"

As Adora embraced her son, Glimmer exchanged a surprised glance with her friend, silently conveying, "We are?"

"Will both finalists please make their way to the ring," boomed the voice over the PA system.

"Good luck, Finn!" the two teleported away. It was time for Finn to showcase the power of the new generation.

Glimmer teleported herself, Adora, and the others to the front row as Finn emerged.

BGM: "Resistance to Resilience" by Reluctant Hero

For what they hoped would be the penultimate time, Finn's entrance theme reverberated throughout the arena. Their hair fluttered in the wind, a fitting tribute to their heritage as the offspring of She-Ra. Finally, after what felt like an eternity, Finn reached ringside, where they were embraced by Catra and Adora. "You've got this, son!" Catra encouraged. Finn nodded and slipped into the ring, ready to face their opponent.

BGM "Metalingus" by Alter Bridge

Large columns of smoke engulfed the stage as Kazari made her final entrance of the night. Staring at each other intently, Finn and Kazari closed the gap between them. Kazari, despite her injured leg, walked with determination, even striking a defiant pose as towers of pyro erupted into the air. Finn watched as their fellow magicat climbed the top rope to wave to her fathers. But now, it was time to get serious as Kazari stepped down from the ropes, preparing for the upcoming battle.

The music faded, and the two finalists continued their intense stare-down. The time for words had passed. The crowd buzzed with anticipation. While Team Grayskull had already secured the overall championship, the Grand Champion would be determined by the outcome of this match. With the ringing of the bell, the battle was underway! Finn lunged forward with a flying clothesline, narrowly evaded by Kazari. Finn retaliated with a flurry of body blows, finding an opening to counter with a monkey flip. Kazari braced her injured knee, using her good leg to land safely just in time for Finn to seize her by the waist, executing a devastating German suplex, followed by a thunderous dropkick that sent Kazari crashing into the turnbuckle.

Throughout the intense exchange, Micah observed the determined magicat, recognizing a familiar resilience and determination. He murmured to himself, "That Kazari... she possesses tremendous potential!"

The two magicats continued their back-and-forth, exchanging forearm strikes and headbutts, with Finn gaining the upper hand. As Finn surged forward, time seemed to slow down, and a realization struck Kazari. Finn was the child of She-Ra, and they should possess greater strength. In a swift move, Kazari crouched and propelled Finn over the ropes, sending them crashing outside the ring, prompting the referee's count. Finn quickly regained their footing but stumbled against the wall. Observing Kazari clutching her injured knee, a realization dawned on Adora. "Finn!" she called out urgently. Finn reluctantly approached the Princess of Power. "I've discovered Kazari's weakness. It's her leg. Whatever magic affected her earlier, it has caused damage. Attack her leg!" Adora instructed. Finn was taken aback. While they understood Adora's desire for victory, they knew it had to be achieved fairly. "Mom, no! I understand you want me to win, but it must be done the right way!" With that, the young magicat rushed back into the ring just in the nick of time. Kazari pointed an accusatory finger at Finn, saying, "Finn, I know you're holding back!" Finn was dumbfounded by the statement. "What are you talking about?" they asked.

"You're the child of the Princess of Power! You should have much greater power than you're showing!"

"You don't understand! I am not defined by my lineage! I am Finn!"

Kazari raised an eyebrow. "Listen, Finn. I understand you may not want to be defined by your heritage. I may not be anyone special, but I get it! You don't want to live in the shadow of your mothers. But you are not them. You are Finn, and the power you've inherited from She-Ra is not her power, it's yours!" she roared. "Now, use it! Show us YOUR power!"

Finn stood in stunned silence, realizing that Kazari, despite not knowing them, had somehow seen through their struggle. Suddenly, the years of being known as "She-Ra's child" and the pressure to live up to expectations flooded their mind.

"RAAAUGH!" Finn exploded, surrounded by a multicolored fiery aura. Their power surged to new heights. Though nowhere near She-Ra's level, it was enough to make the stadium tremble, causing a large piece of the arena structure to collapse onto a man with pink hair and black dots outside.

Overwhelmed by the catharsis of finally unleashing their true potential, Finn exclaimed, "This! THIS IS AMAZING!" The crowd erupted in thunderous applause, and Adora and Catra watched in astonishment, their eyes wide with disbelief. Bow and Glimmer's eyes were on the verge of bursting with excitement. Retro Adora and Juliet stood in stunned silence, while Kazari wore a smirk on her face.

"That's more like it, Finn. To be honest, I was just testing you earlier. Now, FEEL THE BEAT OF MY HAVOK!" Kazari declared. Despite the strain it put on her young body, she summoned her Havok Magic, a jagged green, purple, and red aura radiating around her.

Everyone gasped. "So that IS Havok Magic!" Adora exclaimed.

Micah, astounded by the unfolding events, knew what needed to be done.

Kazari could feel the Havok Magic tearing through her thirteen-year-old body, but her determination

pushed her forward, oblivious to the pain. It was a testament to her unwavering resolve at such a young age.

The two magicats clashed with an unyielding determination. Each blow was met with an even stronger counterattack. Headbutts reverberated like thunder. Kazari's tenacity clashed with Finn's innate warrior spirit, resulting in a magnificent display of power.

Another shockwave blasted both combatants back, signaling the climax of the match. With synchronized battle cries, Finn and Kazari charged toward each other. Just as the final blow was about to land, Kazari's body succumbed to the strain of the Havok

Magic, her leg snapping and muscles tearing. Crying out in pain, Kazari was speared to the mat by Finn, and the referee began the count. "1... 2... 3!!"

"That's it! Finn wins! Finn wins! Ladies and gentlemen, the winner of this match, AND NEW G1 COSMIC TENKAICHI GRAND CHAMPION: Finn and Team Grayskull!"

Catra and Adora rejoiced, joining the Best Friend Squad as they leaped over the barricade to embrace Finn, along with the rest of Team Grayskull. Kazari attempted to roll out of the ring, but ringside doctors advised against it. As Artemy and Pigeon hurried down to comfort their daughter, they encountered an unexpected figure: Micah. The former king of Brightmoon remained silent, producing a small, compact ball of light and pressing it against Kazari's body. Kazari felt the energy course through her, witnessing her body mend and repair itself miraculously. Her leg snapped back into place, and soon enough, her body was fully restored. The young magicat marveled at the feat performed by the master sorcerer. Then, Micah spoke.

"Hey. I'm Micah, and I have a proposition for you!"

Chapter 4- Kazari's Arrival

After an intense day filled with action, it was time for the championship crowning ceremony. Team Grayskull, victorious in their efforts, received a large, ornate crystal trophy held up by Glimmer, Bow, Catra, and Adora. As the Grand Champion, Finn was awarded a big, gold championship belt with their personal insignia etched onto the side plates. Finn proudly raised the belt for everyone to see.

Amidst the celebration, Kazari managed to get to her feet. "Wait, I know you!" exclaimed Artemy.

"You're King Micah of Brightmoon!" added Pigeon.

Kazari, regaining her equilibrium, approached Micah and asked, "What do you mean you have a proposition?"

Micah looked at her and said, "Kazari, that was Havok Magic, wasn't it?"

Kazari nodded cautiously, unsure of where this was leading.

"Kazari, you possess incredible power! I believe I can help you control it, so your body doesn't fall apart again," Micah offered.

Kazari couldn't help but be skeptical. "Ha! I had no idea the great Micah had a sense of humor," she sneered.

Micah, however, was dead serious. "It's no joke. I want you to come train at Mystacor and learn how to better harness your power," he insisted.

Glimmer and Adora noticed the exchange between Micah and Kazari. "Glimmer, did you see that? Let's go over there!" Adora demanded, and Glimmer reluctantly obliged.

"Think about this, Kazari," Artemy advised.

"Yeah, it's a fantastic opportunity for you," Pigeon chimed in.

Kazari crossed her arms, deep in thought. "You know what? Screw it, I'm in. Just call me the Fresh Princess of Mystacor! When do we start?" she exclaimed. Micah laughed heartily. "Well, you're certainly enthusiastic! Take it easy, Kazari. With your fathers' approval, I'll arrange transportation for you in a couple of weeks," he said.

Kazari smirked. "Alright, let's go, dads. I need to start packing!" she declared, grabbing Artemy and Pigeon by the hands, and they left the arena.

Adora and Glimmer had overheard the entire conversation.

Micah turned around to see his stunned daughter and equally surprised Adora. "What? Micah! You can't be serious!" exclaimed Adora. Micah simply smiled and responded, "Oh, trust me. I've never been more serious. I've just found a new student! She'll be coming to Etheria in a couple of weeks. I've always wanted to mentor someone; this is going to be great!"

Adora tilted her head, puzzled. "Right, I'm happy for you, Micah, and I'll let you finish, but why though?" she asked.

The older man sighed. "Well," he began, "I know you all have your issues with... her, but when I knew her as Light Spinner... she was like a mother to me. I loved her as if she were my own mother. She taught me so much, and I owe a lot of my power and wisdom to her. With great power comes great responsibility, you know? Kazari has incredible power and potential, but she clearly needs help controlling and harnessing it," he concluded. Adora struggled to process what she had just heard, but Glimmer only needed a moment to think.

"Well, Dad, if you think this is the right path, then I trust your judgment!" Glimmer

declared resolutely. Micah smiled. "Thank you for understanding, Glimmer." At that moment, Catra and Bow approached the three.

"Hey, Sparkles! Sparkles Sr.! Adora! What's going on?" asked Catra.

"Well, Catra, Micah, in all his infinite wisdom, has decided to recruit Kazari as a new student of Mystacor!" Adora revealed. Catra was taken aback but quickly composed herself. "That's... nice," she managed to say before settling down. "Adora, can we talk?" Adora went off with her wife, while Bow looked at Glimmer.

"Bow," Glimmer said, "do you think...?"

Mara Island, Two Weeks Later...

Hordak and Entrapta did one hell of a job cleaning up Beast Island. Where there was once a desolate hellscape infested with man-eating creatures, now stood a symbol of freedom and hope—a thriving space port for newcomers. A small ship flew low, aligning itself with the strip. Kazari peered out the window, immediately spotting a towering statue of Mara, reminiscent of the Statue of Liberty, holding her sword high. The ship smoothly glided along the strip, eventually coming to a stop at the terminal. Filled with wonder, Kazari readied herself to disembark.

One of the newer members of Brightmoon's Royal Guard stood by, patiently waiting for Kazari to locate the TaxiSkiff that would take her to Liq'Ollem. This guard, stationed outside the skiff, held up a sign with Kazari's name on it. "Ms. Kazari?" the guard called out.

Kazari turned the corner, bags in tow, and her ears perked up at the sound of her name being called. "Ms. Kazari? Ooh, fancy!" she remarked.

As the magicat loaded her luggage, she looked at the guard and flashed a million-dollar grin. "Your next line will be: 'I don't get paid enough for this shit!' Go ahead!"

"I don't get paid enough for this shit!" the guard responded, as instructed.

Liq'Ollem's Mystacor District

In the years that followed the Great War, Mystacor had relocated and merged with Liq'Ollem, expanding its influence into various magical disciplines. This allowed for a greater cultivation of diverse talents, skills, and improved benefits for everyone in Etheria.

"So," Castaspella remarked, "It's a new year for the hallowed halls of Mystacor. Micah, how are you feeling?" Micah let out a nervous sigh. "I won't lie, I'm pretty nervous but also excited. It's my first time as a teacher. I hope I'm up to the task," he confessed. Casta gave Micah a reassuring smile. "Don't worry, you're the greatest sorcerer of our generation. If anyone can inspire these students, it's you!"

"Thanks, Casta. Hey, could you do me a favor and make sure Angie gets her medication?" Micah requested.

"Of course," Casta replied.

As if on cue, the Best Friend Squad teleported right in front of the two siblings. Finn, Archer, and Iyexi accompanied them.

"Finn, Iyexi, Archer, go and play, but stay within our sight. Right now, the grown-ups need to talk," Adora instructed.

Finn rolled their eyes. "Mom, we're 13. You don't have to talk down to us like we're little kids!" they protested.

Catra rolled her eyes too, while Iyexi furrowed her brow and declared, "You know they're right. We're not kids; we're teenagers!" She stomped her feet for emphasis.

"Listen, you three may be teenagers, but you'll always be our babies. Don't act all grown up just because you won the championship!" Glimmer sternly reminded them.

The three exchanged eye rolls as Adora and Glimmer walked away.

"Gee, what a condescending twat," Iyexi commented.

"I heard that!" Glimmer shouted before turning her attention to her father. "So, do you think she's coming?" she asked.

Micah pointed to the sky. "Looks like you're about to find out!" he said as a small shuttle descended

and landed in front of the group. The side door opened, and Kazari's suitcase flew out, hitting the ground with a thud. Moments later, Kazari herself leaped out of the shuttle with a flourish, reminiscent of Dio Brando.

Kazari had arrived.

"Well, I thought Double Trouble had a flair for the dramatic," Catra mused.

Kazari surveyed her surroundings. "Hm, not bad! It's a lot bigger than I expected," she remarked.

"Kazari, welcome to Mystacor," Micah greeted her. "Today marks the beginning of orientation weekend. Take a look around, see if any classes interest you. After you settle in, you can explore the rest of Etheria."

Kazari nodded, grabbed her suitcase, and headed off eagerly, noticing the tense glances exchanged between Adora and Catra. "Micah, are you sure about this? I mean, just look at her!" Adora voiced her concerns.

"Adora, I respect you a great deal, but I think you're being paranoid," Micah replied matter-of-factly. Adora felt a twinge of anger rising within her like a boiling teapot, but she managed to contain it with the help of Glimmer and Bow.

"Easy, Adora. Micah is right. We only have her resemblance to go off of," Glimmer reassured her.

Adora took a deep breath. "You're right. Thanks," she said, grateful for Glimmer's support.

The Queen of Brightmoon smiled. "Of course! Anytime—"

Cough *Cough*

"Catra?"

Catra suddenly succumbed to a violent coughing fit. "Damn it! I need to sit down! I'm fine!" the older magicat insisted.

"Finn," Archer inquired, "Have you noticed how strange Adora has been acting around Kazari?"

"Yeah, no kidding," Finn replied. "I wonder what that's about."

Archer and Iyexi contemplated Kazari's performance in the tournament, how she quickly detected Archer's teleportation movements. Suddenly, a realization struck Archer. "Wait, Finn! Maybe she's exactly what our group needs to reach the next level," they suggested.

Kazari overheard their conversation and smirked. She had always possessed a healthy dose of ego, and hearing the children of the legendary Best Friend Squad talking about her had her feeling invincible. "I'm Kazari. Whatever this little group is about, I'm the MVP. You can just call me the Fresh Princess of Mystacor!" she declared.

Micah approached the trio and placed a hand on Kazari's shoulder. "If you wish to pursue Havok Magic, I'll do my best to assist you. However, I have limited experience with such a rare form of magic. I can guide you in the right direction, but that's about it," he explained. Kazari shrugged off his hand and replied confidently, "Well, I expected as much. That's alright. I'm Kazari, and I know we can do it!"

Micah was taken aback by Kazari's pride and enthusiasm but accepted it.

"Master Micah, I have a feeling we're going to achieve great things together!"

And so, their training began.

Kazari excelled in crafting and wielding weapons, and her control over Havok Magic showed gradual improvement. However, her training was briefly interrupted as she returned to Xisaeus to celebrate her 14th birthday.

Initially, Rose and Iyexi struggled with magical botany and magitech, despite their parentage. But with time, they overcame their obstacles and found their rhythm. Iyex

i even felt confident enough to unleash her powers to a level where she believed she could obliterate the sun, while Rose could create genuine plant golems.

Riley managed to keep up with Spinnerella and Netossa, although the experienced duo still held an edge over her.

Aquajet started with the ability to form water whips for only a few seconds, but she progressed to summoning water aberrations that could fight on her behalf, akin to stands from Jojo's Bizarre Adventure.

Archer's teleportation range initially spanned just a few feet, but now he could jump across entire kingdoms.

Lastly, Finn learned to control their strength and embraced their passion for the theater, influenced by their auncle Double Trouble.

Days turned into weeks.

Weeks became months.

Months transformed into years.

And before they knew it, **five years had elapsed.**

Chapter 5- The New Best Friend Squad Part 1- Desert Flower


ARC 7
THE NEW BEST FRIEND SQUAD

"Finn, Archer, Iyexi. We're so proud of you. It's hard to believe you three are already in your third year!" exclaimed Glimmer with a smile.

Catra chimed in, albeit a bit paler than usual. "Seems like just yesterday we were changing your diapers," she said, a hint of nostalgia in her voice. Adora stood behind her, teary-eyed with pride.

"Oh, Catra, our baby is growing up so fast!" Adora sniffled, her emotions getting the better of her. Catra rolled her eyes playfully. "Dear Gods, Adora, pull it together," she teased.

Interrupting the moment, Kazari leaped in through an open window with excitement. "Hey, Finn! Did you tell your folks the news?" she asked, a mischievous grin on her face.

Adora raised an eyebrow, a sense of curiosity mixed with a tinge of worry. "Finn, what's she talking about?" she asked, her heart racing.

Kazari wrapped her arms around Archer and Finn, fellow magicats, and declared, "Adora, Catra, Glimmer, Bow, say hello to the New Best Friend Squad!" she announced proudly.

Bow and Glimmer gushed over the idea, but Catra found it thoroughly amusing, while Adora felt a punch to her heart. "New... Best Friend Squad?!" she repeated, trying to process the sudden change.

Returning to the present, Kazari, now aged 19, wore a weighted vest and ankle braces as she pushed herself on a one-ton hamster wheel. The red light signaled her to move on, and she sprinted to the next station. Micah watched her with pride as she progressed to a shoulder press.

"Ten reps, Kazari! You're half a second behind. You've got this!" Micah encouraged her, his voice filled with enthusiasm.

Kazari nodded, determination gleaming in her eyes, as she finished the tenth rep and faced the final obstacle—a large warped wall. The weight of her vest and braces threatened to drag her down, but Kazari knew this challenge was about more than just gravity. It was about her drive, her power, and her hunger to succeed. With one final push, she propelled herself up the warped wall, her body pulsing with havok magic, and shattered the actuator, triggering the red light. Breathing heavily, she wiped the sweat from her brow as Micah stopped his watch.

"Kazari, that was your fastest time yet!" he exclaimed, clearly impressed with her progress.

Jumping down from the wall, Kazari proudly kissed her bicep. "Well, I had the best teacher in you, Master Micah!" she declared with a wink, her confidence shining through.

Micah's breath caught in his throat, momentarily taken aback by Kazari's words. Before he could respond, Angella arrived, giving him a peck on the cheek. The couple exchanged greetings, and Angella suggested she put Micah through his own paces.

Blushing, Micah turned to Kazari and said, "Kazari, be a dear. I'm sure your friends are waiting for you. Better not keep them waiting!"

Kazari removed her vest and braces, replying, "Okay, have fun, you two," before running off to the showers. Humming with excitement, she sprinted down the hallway until she abruptly stopped in front of a woman.

The woman, Ohren, regarded Kazari with disdain. "Kazari..."

"Ohren..."

The two locked eyes, a tense silence filling the air. Ohren was the first to speak, her words dripping with

judgment. "Kazari, you're smelly."

Rolling her eyes, Kazari casually replied, "Well, I was just about to hit the showers... actually, I've been meaning to try out a new wardrobe!"

Later, outside the New Mystacor region, Finn anxiously paced while Archer and Iyexi watched with curiosity. Archer reassured Finn, telling them that Kazari could handle anything Micah threw at her.

"Yeah, Finn. Kazari's tough. She'll be fine," Iyexi added, sharing Archer's confidence. "Besides, she mentioned debuting a new look. I'm curious to see what it'll be. She claims it'll be her best look yet. I'll be the judge of that," they remarked playfully.

Archer nodded in agreement, joining the anticipation. Suddenly, their attention was drawn to a transformed Kazari at the top of the steps. Her hair had grown longer, and she now sported a magenta top with a red jacket adorned with orange stripes. A yin-yang symbol graced the side of the jacket, and her forearms were wrapped in sports tape. Her tail was neatly tied around her waist like a belt, completing her new style.



MAXX PHOENIX

“Damn, Kazari! That really is your best look!” said Finn.

Kazari chuckled to herself, saying, “Of course it is, this is ME we’re talking about. I am the Fresh Princess of Mystacor!”

As the four shared a hardy laugh, Rose walked up to them.

“Hey, everyone. Are you ready?” she said, “You guys promised you’d help me out.”

Iyexi went up to her and placed a hand on her shoulder. “Rose, when have we ever let you down?" she asked.

Rose simply stared at the group with a deadpan expression. “Over the past 5 years, of all the kids, Rose was the one who underwent the most change. She now wore a black bra covered by a mesh midriff with black waist high jeans and black lipstick. Also, she’s going through an emo phase.

Kazari walked down the steps, gingerly asking, “So, remind me. What’re we helping out with?”

Rose rolled her eyes. “Wanna know why I’m having the emo phrase right now, despite being Scorpia and Perfuma’s daughter? Kazari, shortly before you came along, mom decided it was a good

idea to hold something called the Unity Festival, basically, every year, she takes everyone in Plumeria, who is 18 or older, and lets call a spade a spade, she organizes a massive orgy. The bitch really takes her free love seriously," she remarked.

Kazari tilted her head. "An orgy you say? I'm 19, do you think I could-"

"NO! DON'T YOU DARE!" Rose roared.

Kazari narrowed her eyes. "Right…so…whatcha need us for?" she asked.

"Both my moms are busy setting everything else up, so they tasked me with collecting a special cactus found in the Crimson Waste. I need her help gathering it!"

Archer perked up, saying, "Oh, maybe Huntara could help us, Finn!"

Finn beamed."YAY! MY REAL MOM!" they said.

Rose raised an eyebrow at this statement, saying, "Uh… Finn….should I be concerned?

Crimson Waste

The transformation of the Crimson Waste over the past 25 years was nothing short of remarkable. With advancements in technology and support from various kingdoms, the stark contrast between then and now was evident, even boasting the presence of a new transit system.

Having honed his teleportation skills, Archer effortlessly transported everyone to the Waste. As Finn breathed in the distinct scent of the rustic air, they couldn't help but reflect, "Kazari, the Crimson Waste has always felt like a second home to me."

Kazari raised an eyebrow, amused by Finn's comment. "Well, considering you just referred to that Huntara lady as your 'other real mom,' I have no doubts about that," she quipped.

Interrupting the banter, Rose interjected, "Anyway, we need to move quickly. We don't want to keep our moms waiting. Finn, take the lead."

Finn nodded and replied, "Indeed, we do require Huntara's assistance. According to the grapevine, the Waste has undergone significant changes recently. We need to gather all the necessary information before proceeding."

Rose acknowledged Finn's words and motioned for the five of them to join hands. "Archer, you know what to do," she said with determination.

Archer nodded, a mischievous glint in his eyes. "Next stop, Huntara's hut!" he declared before whisking them away to their destination.

Valley of the Lost

In the midst of her intense workout session, the formidable warrior of the Crimson Waste was busy pumping iron, the clangs and bangs reverberating through the air. As she hoisted the barbell over her head, the sudden teleportation of the squad startled her, causing her to drop the weight, narrowly avoiding a potential injury. It was a relief, as nobody wanted a repeat of the infamous "Paging Dr. Drake" incident.

"Hi, real mom!" Finn's enthusiastic voice filled the room.

Huntara quickly regained her composure upon recognizing Finn's voice. "Ah, Finn. What brings you here?" she inquired.

Finn scratched the back of their head, sheepishly replying, "Well, we're actually here for Rose!"

Stepping forward, Rose greeted Huntara with a forced smile. "Hey, Huntikins!" she said, to which Huntara responded with a grimace.

"Rose, I'm going to have a serious talk with your mothers. So, what do you need my help with?" the desert warrior asked, her tone laced with a hint of annoyance.

Rose pulled out a mini-tablet and showed Huntara a picture of the Cyclone Cactus. "It's called a Cyclone Cactus. Legend has it that it was formed during a freak storm. Apparently, it has sprouted in the Valley of the Lost. We'll need your skiff since Archer can't teleport without an exact location. As a half-Perfuma, I can sense the general range. Plus, the cactus is rumored to be quite large, hence the need for the skiff," Rose explained.

Huntara took a seat and tapped her chin thoughtfully. "A cactus, huh? And you're Perfuma's crotch goblin? Figures!" the warrior scoffed, tossing the keys to Finn. She warned them, "Finn, you're in charge! I better not see a single scratch on that thing! Oh, and by the way, there have been reports of an incoming sandstorm. Judging by the sound of it, it's going to be a massive one, so move quickly!"

Crimson Waste Outer Desert...

The five individuals piloted Huntara's skiff over the vast expanse of desert sands. Securely fastened on the back of the skiff were several large crates, containing their sought-after cargo. Rose sat in deep concentration, her focus evident to Kazari who glanced at the scorpion-flower princess and asked, "Rose, are you all good?" In response, Rose replied with determination, "Yeah, I'm trying to sense the general location of vegetation!"

Curiosity piqued, Finn inquired, "So, how will you know where the cactus is?"

Rose chuckled halfheartedly. "Well, Finn, since I'm familiar with the sensations most plants give off, I just need to feel for anything unfamiliar. And there it is!" she exclaimed, shooting up and pointing eastward.

Nodding in understanding, Finn swiftly turned the skiff to the east, causing everyone to brace themselves as the vehicle shook, rattled, and rolled. But this was Huntara's skiff—it thrived in such thrilling moments.

"Just beyond the next dune!" Rose announced, prompting Kazari to shout, "Full speed ahead!"

Finn was more than happy to comply, powering the skiff to its maximum potential as it soared over the dune with the grace of a nimble gazelle. Suddenly, Finn brought the skiff to a screeching halt, catching everyone off guard.

"What's wrong, Finn?" Iyexi inquired.

Finn pointed toward the sight before them. Two large gangs stood in front of a cave. On one side stood Fang Ripper, a robust reptilian woman with a dark red complexion, while on the other side stood Mantanna, an equally husky man with a dark blue complexion.

"So, tell me, Fang Ripper," Mantanna began, "did you honestly believe that your father's gang, Tung Lasher's, could outmatch my crew?"

Fang Ripper's eye twitched angrily. "What the hell did you just say, you wanker?"

To worsen matters, the coveted cacti were situated at the base of the nearby cave, obstructed by the presence of the two dangerous gangs on the verge of tearing each other apart.

Finn clenched their teeth, realizing the gravity of the situation. "This is bad. It seems like a full-blown gang war is about to erupt."

Without warning, Kazari removed her jacket and tossed it to her fellow magicat. "Finn, hold my jacket. This won't take long," she declared with conviction.

Before anyone could protest, Kazari leaped from the skiff and walked up to the two gang leaders.

"Hey, you two! Take this elsewhere," Kazari commanded, her voice carrying a no-nonsense tone.

The two gang leaders stared daggers at Kazari, their intense gazes enough to slay her a hundred times over.

"Kazari, please be careful!" Archer cautioned.

"Damn it! What is Kazari doing?" Rose fretted.

"She's going to get herself messed up or even killed!" Iyexi exclaimed.

Finn stood stoically, closely observing the imminent clash.

Fang Ripper confronted Kazari, getting in her face. "So, punk, you think you can be a hero?"

Kazari responded with a sly smirk. "For one of you, the next line will be, 'Why are you sticking your nose where it doesn't belong?' Go!"

Just as expected, Mantanna retorted, "Why are you sticking your nose where it doesn't belong? Huh?"

Fang Ripper instinctively reached into her pants pocket, but Kazari swiftly intercepted, remarking, "If you're looking for your

dagger, check your long coat pocket!"

To Fang Ripper's astonishment, the dagger was indeed found there.

"Your next words are, 'What are you, a mind reader?' Go!" Kazari continued.

True to form, Fang Ripper uttered in disbelief, "What are you, a mind reader? Fuck! How?"

Kazari smirked, explaining her deductions. "I noticed that the blood on your jacket doesn't belong to you. And I saw the marks in your palm."

Mantanna burst into laughter. "Damn, she made you look like a fool, an even bigger one! Haha!"

Narrowing her eyes, Kazari retorted, "What the hell are you two laughing at? Nobody calls me a bitch without my consent!" With that, she unraveled her arm tape, swiftly wrapping it around the two gang leaders, and unleashed a powerful blast of havok magic,

rendering them unconscious. As Kazari reapplied her tape, she couldn't help but notice a bruise forming on her forearm.

"Damn it," she muttered. "Now your leaders will be fine. Take them and get lost. A sandstorm is approaching."

The gangs didn't argue, hastily grabbing their respective leaders and retreating to wherever they came from.

Kazari turned back to her group, exclaiming, "Okay, everything's clear!" Archer and the others linked up and teleported to Kazari's location as Archer placed a hand on her shoulder. "You know what? I'll never doubt your judgment again!" he admitted.

Kazari winked at him and replied, "Was there ever any doubt? After five years, you should know that I—WHOA!" Suddenly, she tripped over an object protruding from the sand. Kazari rubbed her bottom as Finn helped her up and handed her the jacket.

"Kazari, are you alright?" Iyexi asked.

The redhead swiftly got to her feet, donning her jacket once more and giving Finn a thumbs-up. "Yeah, I'm fine. But did I trip on something?" Kazari knelt down to examine what had caused her stumble. Her eyes widened in astonishment as she pulled out a dark purple and neon green ram's head. "Whoa! Is this what I think it is? Finn, guys, check this out!" she called excitedly.

They gathered around Kazari, and it was Finn who spoke up. "Kazari! I've heard about that! That's a piece of a havok staff! My uncle, Adam, told me about this guy named Skeletor who used a havok staff. It's used to channel havok magic. Kazari, you could do something amazing with this!"

Kazari tapped her chin, contemplating the possibilities. "Hey, I have a history report coming up. I could use this for that."

Rolling her eyes, Rose groaned, "Yeah, because that definitely won't backfire on you at some point. Kazari, that's a havok staff. It could be dangerous."

Kazari shrugged, firing back, "Well, not as dangerous as being out here with a sandstorm brewing!" Just as if on cue, a sudden gust of wind blew by. "Uh-oh, speaking of which, we'd better move, and quickly!"

Everyone grabbed the crates and hurriedly made their way to the base of the nearby cave, where a cluster of cacti with iridescent spiral patterns awaited. They were undeniably beautiful, explaining Perfuma's desire for them at her Unity Festival. However, there was no time to admire their allure. Rose pressed her hands to the ground, causing the cacti to lift out of the

sand and into the crates. After a while, the crates were filled and loaded onto the skiff.

Rose wiped the sweat off her brow and thanked her friends. "Thanks, guys," she said, grateful for their help.

Iyexi placed a hand on her shoulder and replied, "Of course. We're the Best Friend Squad, after all, right, Finn? Finn?"

"Catra, it's your fault Finn is so rude to us!"

"Me?!"

"Yes, you! They learn it from you!"

"I beg your fucking pardon?!"

Snap *Snap* "Hey! Etheria to Finn!" Iyexi snapped, startling the half-magicat.

"Huh? Shit, sorry. I don't know, I think I just zoned out. I don't know what came over me!" Finn apologized, their cheeks turning as red as Kazari's hair.

Iyexi activated her visor to check the time and gasped. "Guys, that sandstorm is going to hit in about 30 minutes! We need to move!"

"Go! GO!" Kazari urged as everyone boarded the skiff, and they swiftly took off, leaving the imminent sandstorm behind.

Back at Huntara's hut...

Huntara lay in bed, entwined with a nameless woman she had met at a bar. The aftermath of their passionate encounter was evident, but the warrior's attention was drawn to the window. A sandstorm raged outside, shrouding the Waste in swirling clouds of dust.

"Oh, damn it!" Huntara exclaimed, concern etched on her face. "I hope those kids made it out safely!"

As if on cue, Rose, Kazari, Finn, Archer, and Iyexi materialized within the hutt, bringing with them crates and a visible layer of dust. Rose managed to regain her footing, coughing as she expelled the intrusive particles. Despite the dusty aftermath, she mustered a shaky thumbs-up and declared, "Mission accomplished!"

Plumeria Festival Grounds...

"Thanks, everyone!" Perfuma expressed her gratitude. Rose nodded in acknowledgement, her cheeks still flushed with embarrassment. The flower princess turned to the rest of the group and posed a question, "Hey, are you guys all over 18? Would you like to join us at the festival?"

Rose fought the urge to deliver a well-deserved smack to her mother right then and there, her face matching the fiery hues of

her hair. Kazari noticed Rose's discomfort and swiftly changed the subject, sensing the need to redirect the conversation.

"So, Perfuma, what's the purpose of the cacti?" Kazari inquired, attempting to steer the conversation away from awkward territory.

Perfuma's face lit up as she gestured toward a stage. "We've received a special request from Castaspella. She's going to perform at the Unity Festival, and we'll be using cacti as decorative elements. By the way, Kazari, I value your opinion. We're planning to incorporate flowers as well. Which flowers do you think would be best?"

Kazari tapped her chin in contemplation before settling on her choice. "Daisies... I've always found them to be cheerful."

Chapter 6- The New Best Friend Squad Part 2- Sick Day

A few days later...

The dummy thicc wind princess that was Spinnerella, felt as though she was on the verge of melting into a puddle of mucus. Her head spun relentlessly as she curled up in a chair. Meanwhile, her wife, Netossa, was enduring a similar fate. She had already vomited multiple times and now suffered from a sore neck and shortness of breath.

"Oh, gods, Spinny. Everything hurts! And let me tell you, it's not my fault!" Netossa exclaimed, her voice strained.

Spinnerella raised an eyebrow. "Netossa, let's settle this with a vote!" she suggested flatly.

"Spinny, you must be even sicker than both of us if you think a vote will change anything. There are only two of us! What the hell would voting achieve?" Netossa retorted, attempting to raise her voice but only managing to cough uncontrollably.

Meanwhile, their son, Riley, leaned against the wall, joined by Kazari, Finn, Iyexi, and Archer.

"You see what I mean?" Riley commented, keeping a safe distance.

"Spinny, Nets, you two look like absolute shite!" Kazari deadpanned.

"Dude!" Riley shot a glare at Kazari before turning his attention to his mothers. "Um... Mommy? Are you two okay?"

Netossa struggled to sit up but failed. "Well, my chest feels like it's being crushed, and I feel like I was skullfucked by He-Man. What do you think?" she replied with a pout.

Spinnerella let out a harsh cough. "Riley, please put me out of my misery!" she pleaded, clearly delirious.

Iyexi winced as she activated her visor to scan Spinnerella and Netossa's temperature. "Holy crap, you two are burning up!" the half-spacebat exclaimed. "Are you sure you're okay?"

Spinnerella let out a sigh and said, "I don't know. Something bit us yesterday, and now we both feel like we're on the brink of death!"

Archer scratched the back of his head and asked, "So, Riley, what exactly do you need us to do?"

"Right, so... we need to gather some ingredients to make a healing broth or something before my moms keel over," Riley explained.

Netossa managed to sit up a bit more this time and reassured Riley, "It's alright, son. We'll be fine. We just need a little rest and relaxa-BLEEEEEEHHHHH!!" Suddenly, Netossa's stomach convulsed, and she expelled a massive stream of bile, half-digested food, and debris.

Riley jumped back, watching in horror. "Oh, geez, Mom!"

Spinnerella desperately tried to shield herself from the onslaught, using her arms as a feeble barrier. "EWEWEWEWEWEEEEW!" she cried out.

The squad exchanged worried glances, with Finn remarking, "Damn, that's rough!"

Spinnerella attempted to conjure a protective shield of wind to block the stream but lacked the energy to do so. All she could manage was to protect herself with her arms. "Please, Riley, hurry!" she whimpered, using what little strength she had to wipe away the vomit.

Elberon

As Kazari arrived in Elberon, her mind immediately flashed back to her first visit with Micah, helping gather ingredients for a special tea for Angella. It had been a pleasant memory.

"Alright, everyone. Here are the lists of items we need for the brew," Riley announced, distributing small slips of paper. With the papers in hand, the group seemed to split into separate cliques. Kazari and Finn hurried off, while Iyexi and Archer stayed with Riley.

"I swear, those two have been inseparable since Kazari arrived," Riley remarked.

Iyexi casually placed her hands behind her head and said, "Well, Archer and I have a little bet going on. I'm pretty sure Kazari and Finn are going to end up together, someday!"

Riley grimaced. "Oh, for the love of Jebuss Krist... You really shouldn't make bets on that kind of stuff," he said, his face turning red with embarrassment.

Archer cleared his throat, attempting to change the subject. "Right... So, let's focus on getting the items. Do we need noodles?"

Meanwhile, Kazari and Finn strolled through the town, immediately sensing that something was amiss.

"Kaz, is it just me, or does everyone seem... tense?" Finn asked, voicing the observation.

Indeed, people around them appeared on edge. A woman was frantically trying to enter her house, and a little girl clung desperately to her father, reminiscent of Gollum's grip on the ring.

It was then that the mayor, Elena, approached the two. "Finn, son of Sir Adora and Lady Catra. Kazari, student of Micah. It's good to see both of you, but you should exercise caution."

"Mayor Elena, hey! How's it going?" Finn greeted.

Elena looked weary but managed a warm smile. She was a slender woman with an olive complexion and a pixie haircut.

"To be honest, I've seen better days. We've seen better days," Elena replied.

Kazari raised an eyebrow and inquired, "So, what exactly is happening here?"

With a sigh, Elena explained, "There have been rumors circulating, and they've become quite credible, about a monster taking the form of a spider."

Intrigued, Kazari sought more information. "I see. Why not contact one of the princesses?" the magicat suggested.

"Well," Elena began, "Spinnerella and Netossa tried to assist yesterday, but now they're both sick. That's why everyone is on edge. Perfuma is busy preparing for the upcoming festival, and honestly, we don't believe we should rely solely on the princesses to solve all our problems..."

Finn smirked. "Now that's an idea I can get behind!" they remarked.

Taking a step forward, Kazari addressed the mayor. "If there have been sightings of a monster, then the Best Friend Squad is here to help. Consider it our new side quest!"

Some time later, the group gathered at a cafe, and Kazari ordered milk for everyone. "Alright, here's the new plan," she announced. "Apparently, there are rumors of a monster lurking deep in the woods. I'm willing to bet that's the cause of Spinny and Netossa's illness."

Finn raised an eyebrow and questioned, "Kaz, are you suggesting that we become monster hunters?"

Kazari nodded with determination. "That's precisely what I'm suggesting!"

"But... what about our moms?" Riley stuttered, expressing his concern.

Kazari flashed him a million-dollar smile, assuring him, "Don't worry, Riley. Your moms are Spinnerella

and Netossa! They fought in the war. I'm sure they can hold on a little longer. I trust they're handling it with grace and finesse."

Meanwhile, Spinnerella and Netossa were far from graceful and composed in their illness. Scorpia had arrived to help, only to find Netossa curled up in a fetal position and Spinnerella whimpering, face down on the floor, with Netossa's dried vomit still on the side of her face.

"What the hell happened?!" Scorpia exclaimed in shock.

Spinnerella struggled to sit up and explained, "Well, Netossa puked all over me. I tried to get up and wipe it off, but *sniff* I ended up collapsing and landed on my bad ankle. It hurts so much... WAAHH!"

Scorpia knelt down and pulled the dummy thicc wind princess into an embrace. "Shh... It's okay. Mama Scorps is here. I'll take such good care of you guys!"

Netossa threw her head back incredulously and cried out, "RILEY!!! PLEASE, HURRY!!!"

Back in Elberon, Kazari led the group toward the edge of the Whispering Woods. "Keep your eyes peeled, everyone. According to Elena, the monster resembles a spider. So, if we come across it, we need to..." Kazari's voice trailed off as she became entranced, fixated on a tree that seemed to distort in her vision. The distortions took on a shape she couldn't quite decipher. Iyexi waved a hand in front of Kazari's face, prompting her to blink rapidly and snap back to reality. "Whoa, that was weird!"

"Kaz, are you alright? You zoned out for a moment," Archer inquired.

"I'm not sure... I thought I saw something. Come on!" Kazari responded.

"Oh, geez, Kazari. I'm not so sure about this. You're apparently hallucinating now. What if you caught your moms' sickness?" Riley expressed his concern.

Kazari dismissed his worries with a hand wave. "Nah, I think I just saw something, but I'll deal with it later. Right now, we have a spider to deal with."

Iyexi placed a comforting hand on Archer's shoulder. "Don't worry, this is Kazari we're talking about. She always finds a way."

"Oh... I sure hope so," Archer replied with a hint of apprehension.

Kazari stepped forward, cutting through tall bushes and shrubbery, until she stumbled upon something. "Guys, look, a spider web!"

The web emitted a soft glow, shifting between shades of thalo blue and crime scene red. Kazari and Riley knelt down to examine it. "Riley, being half-Netossa, do you recognize the composition of this web?" Kazari asked.

Riley nodded. "No, this strange webbing appears to be... not entirely organic."

Kazari tapped her chin thoughtfully before grabbing the nearest stick and prodding the web, causing it to glitch and undulate. Stepping back, Kazari and Riley watched as the web suddenly burst into acidic goop.

"What the fuck?!" Iyexi exclaimed.

"Interesting!" Kazari remarked.

"Kazari, you really scare me sometimes," Riley said with a mix of fear and amusement.

Finn playfully draped an arm over Kazari's shoulder. "Hey, everyone's a critic these days, huh, Kaz?" they teased.

Kazari furrowed her brow, deep in thought. The webs before them didn't seem ordinary—these were designed for inflicting damage rather than ensnaring prey. "Iyexi, do me a favor and collect a sample," she instructed, her voice laced with determination. "We might find some valuable clues in this spider goop."

Iyexi, with a look of disgust on her face, swiftly gathered samples using a plastic bag and cotton swabs. "This is downright repulsive," she muttered under her breath.

Archer chimed in, his voice edged with concern. "The spider can't be too far from here."

Finn, eyes filled with curiosity, turned to Kazari. "So, what's the plan? Which direction should we go?"

Before Kazari could respond, her eyes widened in alarm. "Riley, watch out!" With lightning speed, she tackled Riley to the ground, narrowly avoiding a barrage of sharp needles that whizzed past them.

Finn, Archer, and Iyexi recoiled in shock, their gaze fixated on their assailant—the spider, a monstrosity of a creature, looming large like a dog gone rogue.

"Jesus Christ!" Riley exclaimed, shaken by the close call.

Kazari sprang back up, pulling Riley to his feet. Her voice resonated with a steely determination. "This must be the fiend responsible for your moms' illness. It's time to bring it down!"

Finn, Archer, and Iyexi rallied around Kazari, their eyes fixed on her, seeking guidance in this treacherous situation. Archer spoke up, his voice tinged with urgency. "Kaz, what's the plan?"

Kazari turned to Riley, her voice low and urgent. "Riley, as half Netossa, you possess the skills. Can you handle tossing nets?"

Riley, uncertainty written across his face, shrugged. "I may not have my mother's full potential, but I'll make it count."

With a nod of reassurance, Kazari leaned in close, whispering something to Riley before declaring, "Riley, run as fast as you can! We'll take it from here!"

Without a second thought, Riley bolted deeper into the woods, seeking refuge. The remaining squad members formed a determined line, facing the hissing arachnid with unwavering resolve. The spider, with its dark iridescent body and a blood-red pattern etched across its back, exuded an aura of danger that sent shivers down their spines.

Kazari clenched her fist, her gaze unwavering. Then, with a sudden twist, she yelled, "Run away!" The others wasted no time and sprinted through the dense woods, the spider hot on their heels. As the pursuit intensified, Kazari and Finn dropped to all fours, unleashing their primal instincts to gain ground.

"Where are we headed, Kazari?!" Finn gasped between breaths.

Kazari flashed a mischievous grin, her eyes gleaming with excitement. "You're about to find out!"

Fueled by adrenaline, Kazari and Finn surged ahead, bounding over a hill, and there it was—a haphazardly woven web, created by Riley's fatigue-stricken hands.

"Good work, Riley!" Iyexi commended, her voice tinged with relief.

Kazari's gaze narrowed, her voice resolute. "Finn, you and I will take the top corners. Archer and Iyexi, secure the bottom!"

The spider inched closer, its four piercing cerulean eyes radiating a sinister blend of malice and fury. Kazari and Finn leaped onto the web, seizing the top corners, while Archer and Iyexi secured the bottom, ensnaring the beast within the woven trap. The spider thrashed and wriggled, its legs tearing at the nets, but Kazari knew time was of the essence.

Tightening her grip, Kazari bellowed, "Silky Spider Thread Havok OVERDRIVE!" A surge of havoc magic surged through the nets, electrifying the spider. The creature convulsed, a cataclysmic explosion ripping it apart, showering the surroundings with smoldering guts and entrails.

Riley winced, his face contorting in discomfort as he surveyed the grim scene before him. Kazari, wearing a smug grin, shook her hand vigorously, trying to shake off the unpleasant tingling sensation. "Well, well, that takes care of that," she declared, her voice dripping with confidence. "Come on, team! Let's go check on the town! ARCHER!"

The group swiftly formed a tight formation as Archer skillfully teleported them back to Elberon. However, what awaited them was a sight that sent chills down their spines. The town lay shrouded in ethereal spiderwebs, and its inhabitants cowered in fear, seeking refuge from an unseen menace. Undeterred, Kazari raised her voice, attempting to instill courage. "Fear not, everyone! We've got this under control!"

Suddenly, a skeptical man poked his head out of a nearby window and voiced his doubt. "Are you sure about that?"

Before anyone could process his words, a massive needle shot past the squad, piercing Riley's shoulder and sending him crashing to the ground. Archer hurried to his side, concern etched on his face. "Are you alright?"

Riley's complexion turned ashen, beads of sweat forming on his forehead. He grimaced, the pain overwhelming him. "Oh, my God! It hurts everywhere. My head is spinning, and I feel like I'm about to vomit!"

Kazari scanned the surroundings, searching for the source of the attack, but her gaze quickly fell upon an even more daunting sight—a colossal spider, its size rivaling that of a storage building, looming menacingly over Elena's home.

Finn's exclamation echoed the shock shared by the entire group. "Holy shit!"

Iyexi, her voice laced with realization, identified the creature as the mother spider and the cause of Spinny and Netossa's illness. "That must be the culprit."

Meanwhile, the man in the window shouted in despair, "We're all going to die!" But Kazari swiftly turned, her voice brimming with determination. "Or perhaps not! Yesterday, I ventured into the Valley of the Lost, and you wouldn't believe what I unearthed from beneath the sand!"

Archer, still cradling the injured Riley, couldn't contain his curiosity. "Kazari, what are you—" His question was promptly answered when Kazari produced a weathered Horde Soldier Blaster.

Iyexi couldn't contain her surprise. "That's an old Horde Blaster!"

Kazari nodded, a mischievous glimmer in her eyes. "You bet it is, and I've given it a havoc extension!"

With a sly smirk, Kazari aimed the weapon, channeling her chaotic energy through its chamber and barrel, unleashing a barrage of destructive fire upon the spider mother.

Riley, now consumed by a raging fever, stared wide-eyed at the audacious display before him. "What the fuck? I always knew she was a bit unhinged, but this? In front of the gods and everyone? It's mind-blowing! Where the hell did she even get that gun? And why is she wreaking havoc on the entire village?"

Kazari let out a furious roar, relentless in her assault on the colossal spider, until the strain on the limited havoc magic proved too much for the worn-out weapon, causing it to explode. Kazari stumbled backward, but a triumphant smile played upon her lips as the blast was enough to dislodge the spider from its perch. The creature quickly recovered, hissing with venomous rage, its many eyes filled with loathing.

Without hesitation, Kazari scooped up Riley, carrying him in

a bridal hold, her voice resolute. "We'll divert its attention while the rest of you grab its legs. We're heading to Spinny and Netossa's house. Archer, get ready to teleport. I've devised a plan!"

"What? Kazari, what's the plan?" Archer began, but before he could finish his question, Kazari darted forward, leaping onto the spider's back while the others grabbed hold of its legs.

"Now, Archer!"

Archer tightened his grip and swiftly teleported outside Spinnerella and Netossa's house, gently placing Riley next to them.

"What... Oh no, Riley, not you too!" Netossa exclaimed, her voice filled with concern.

Finn and Iyexi deftly dodged the spider's needle projectiles while Kazari grabbed Archer's hand, teleporting them both onto the rooftop.

"Archer! Do you have your arrows?" Kazari inquired.

"Do you even have to ask?" Archer replied, producing a collapsible bow and arrow set.

"Together!" Kazari shouted.

Finn and Iyexi managed to redirect the spider's attention, causing it to turn its back to Kazari and Archer, who drew their arrows back, crackling with Kazari's havoc magic. "Here we go, Archer! Arrowshot Havok Overdrive!" They released the arrows, which soared through the air like comets, finding their mark on the spider's back. Bullseye! The creature convulsed as electricity surged through its body, and it exploded in a shower of guts and ectoplasm.

Last time, Iyexi miraculously avoided getting dirty, but this time, luck was not on her side. Suffice to say, she ended up covered in the spider's remains.

Spinnerella, Netossa, and Riley suddenly felt a wave of relief, as if a refreshing breeze had washed over them. It was as if they had never been sick at all. "Whoa, I feel so much better all of a sudden!" Riley remarked.

Spinny and Netossa shot up, quickly went outside, and surveyed the aftermath. "Okay, this is actually very concerning," Netossa remarked, her tone laced with worry.

Kazari and Archer gracefully leaped down from the roof, giving the two women a thumbs up.

"Well, it seems like you're feeling better," Kazari commented.

Spinnerella remained silent, her thoughts racing as she pondered the origin of the colossal spider.

Netossa stepped forward, expressing her gratitude. "Thanks for your help. Can you also do us a favor and extend our thanks to Scorpia? We appreciate it!"

The squad exchanged triumphant fist bumps, but Spinnerella interjected, raising an important question. "This is all well and good, but who's going to clean up this mess?" In response, Netossa approached her with a broom, dustpan,a sluttly maid outfit and a playful smirk.

"Yeah, that seems about right!"

Chapter 7-The New Best Friend Squad Arc Part 3- Sea-Worthy Smash

Sealinies

Surrounded by Kazari, Finn, Iyexi and Archer, Maila faced her mom, the majestic Mermista. Exhaustion veiled Mermista's features. Being a mom was a hard job, especially when one of your kids was a manchild named Seahawk.

"So, like, what's up, mom?" Maila blurted, hands on her hips.

With a hand massaging her temples, Mermista began, "Okay, so, my spies tell me there's this weird cache box thingy floating around in the open sea. It's, like, radiating some strange vibes."

"So, I guess you want us to go play detective, huh?" Maila's voice dripped with sarcasm.

Mermista let out a long, tired sigh. "Maila, you're gonna be queen one day. Your dad and I thought this would be good for you. You know, learning on the job?" Mermista fetched a pair of keys and lobbed them towards Maila.

"Take the Dragon's Daughter 7. Try to forget that you're half-Seahawk and don't fuck this up, okay?"

Maila caught the keys mid-air, stuck her tongue out at her mom. "Well, mom, that snarkiness is why dad scores higher on my favorite parent scale!"

Mermista retaliated by launching her trident at her, missing by miles.

"Haha, missed, bitch!"

"Just scram before I break your neck!"

The Open Sea

Maila was in her element on the Dragon's Daughter 7, feeling like she ruled the world. "Yay!" she screamed, her voice swallowed by the ocean breeze. Kazari leaned lazily against the railing, idly swirling sparks of havok magic between her fingers. "So," she began, "has your mother been a moody bitch-canou?"

Maila chuckled lightly, "Yeah, but she's still pretty cool. She once made sure Finn's trauma isn't worse than it is…" she droned.

Kazari furrowed her brow, the magicat's head tilted slightly.

“Trauma? Maila, what the fuck are you-?”

Maila pointed to the other magicat, Finn, curled up in the fetal position, while Archer and Iyexi were doing their best to confront them. “Finn, just relax, okay?” said Archer.

“We got you, buddy!” Iyexi held Finn’s hand.

“Finn?” Kazari approached her fellow magicat. “Are you okay?” she asked, her aussie accent softened over the years.

Finn looked up at Kazari, saying, “Y-yeah, I will be once we finish this damn mission!”

"Don't sweat it, Finn! You can have a good sob with your moms once we're done!" Kazari jested, a glint of mischief in her eyes.

"Actually, I can't really be around my moms at the moment…"

"Wow, way to rain on the fun parade..." Kazari responded, her teasing tone deflating a bit.

Maila was busy fiddling with a radar when a blip appeared on the screen. "Hey, guys, I think we've got a hit!"

Everyone rose from their spots and huddled around the mermaid-pirate princess. There it was, the cache box, several feet beneath them.

"Alright, looks like this box is tucked away in a sea cave! Kazari, I could use your help hauling this thing, it seems pretty hefty. Your havoc magic should do the trick," she explained, handing out wetsuits to the team.

Kazari merely nodded, stripping down to her underwear, leaving Finn blushing like a ripe tomato. Kazari didn't miss a beat, she winked at the flustered magicat, taunting, “Guess you've hit the jackpot, tiger. Snap a picture, it'll last longer,” before wriggling into her wetsuit, and the others followed her lead.

One by one, everyone dived into the azure depths with the only expectation being Finn who said, “You guys go ahead, I’ll…stay back and watch the boat…”

Maila shot them an empathetic look as she dived in. Maila's seafoam green jacket melted around her legs, which fused into an aquamarine fish tail.

"Alright, stay close," Maila directed, speeding off into the depths with the rest of the team in her wake.

Kazari lagged slightly, swimming alongside Archer and Iyexi. She asked, "What's up with Finn? They seem off-kilter."

"Finn has a thing about water, but it's their story to share, not ours," Iyexi replied, a serious undertone in her voice. Kazari simply nodded in response, understanding the sentiment.

As they neared the cave entrance, Maila called out, "We're here. Kazari, you're up with me."

“Got it,” Kazari replied, swimming up to join Maila at the cave's entrance. The other two hung back slightly, providing cover and watching out for any surprises.

The underwater cave was darker than the surrounding sea, its entrance guarded by a mess of coral and sea plants swaying lazily in the current. Maila and Kazari had to maneuver carefully to avoid disturbing the fragile underwater life. Once past the entrance, they turned on the small lights attached to their suits, illuminating the gloomy interior.

The water inside the cave was cooler and eerily still, reflecting the beams of their lights in strange, distorted patterns on the rough cave walls. They advanced slowly, the silence broken only by the sound of their own breathing and the occasional crackle from their comms devices.

There it was, nestled among an outcropping of rocks, the cache box. Its metallic surface was half-buried in the sand and encrusted with layers of marine life, making it seem more like a part of the cave than an alien object.

Maila signaled to Kazari, pointing towards the box. With a determined nod, Kazari conjured her havoc magic. The sparks danced around her arms and core before reaching out towards the box, lifting it gently from its bed of sand and rocks.

Just when they thought everything was going smoothly, Kazari's eyes widened at a pattern she spotted. It was unmistakably similar to those cursed spiders they had encountered before.

"What the hell?" Kazari blurted out.

"Kazari, what's up?!" Archer and Iyexi's voices crackled through the comms, their concern palpable.

Maila followed Kazari's gaze just in time to see the sand beneath them begin to swirl and shift. "Guys, we need to move, now! We're not alone down here!"

Before they could react, the ocean floor erupted in a cloud of sand and debris. As the dust cleared, a massive, monstrous squid revealed itself.

"HOLY SHIT!!!" Iyexi's exclamation was barely audible over the chaos.

"We have to secure the box!" Maila commanded, doing her best to keep her cool in the face of the terrifying creature. As the squid lunged at them, they swam as fast as they could, the cache box in tow. Their hearts pounded in their chests, the adrenaline fueling their swift escape.

Through gritted teeth, Kazari shouted, "Alright, I'll keep the squid busy, you guys secure the box!"

"On it!"

Without wasting any more time, they all lunged forward, each grabbing a corner of the cache box. Maila, thanks to her mermaid physiology, found the task easier. A mermaid's strength is volumetric - directly proportional to the amount of water in contact with her body. In the vastness of the open sea, Maila was easily the strongest among them.

As they struggled with the box, Kazari swam headfirst into the fray. Her aim was to distract the gigantic squid long enough for the others to make their escape. It was a dangerous plan, but it was all they had. With a deep breath, she charged towards the monstrous creature, ready to face it head-on.

With a determined look, Kazari summoned her havok magic. Electricity crackled around her, creating an impressive, almost mesmerizing display. It felt like pins and needles pricking her

scalp, but she had to ignore it. And just as she hoped, the squid turned its focus to her, tentacles lunging in her direction.

Seizing her moment, Kazari pushed off the cave wall, dodging the squirming tentacles with agile precision. She swam underneath the box and latched onto Maila’s tail, swimming swiftly to join the group.

"Archer, teleport us out of here, now!" Kazari's voice was firm, carrying the urgency of their predicament. They needed to get out, and they needed to do it fast. Archer did just that, warping the four, and the box onto the boat, in front of a perplexed Finn.

"Are you serious?!" Finn's voice echoed through the communication devices as the crew scampered back onto the Dragon's Daughter 7. Maila made a beeline for the console, revving up the ship's engines and steering them away from the underwater chaos.

Minutes later, when they were safely away from the giant squid and the adrenaline had started to wane, Finn repeated their earlier question, this time more slowly, "Can somebody please tell me what the FUCK just happened?"

Maila, steadying her breath, managed to give them a succinct answer: "Giant squid. But we did get the cache box!" She hoped that her words carried some reassurance. Despite the unexpected challenges, they'd succeeded in their mission.

“Welp, in any case, let’s crack this fucker open,” said Kazari.

Wanting to contribute, Finn popped out their claws and broke off the lock. Inside the box, were all aging weapons: an armcannon, a trident, a set of power boosting gloves, bow and arrows and a short sword and sheath.

At first, their faces reflected nothing but underwhelmed surprise. This was what they had risked their lives for? A bunch of old, worn-out weapons? But then, the realization dawned on them. These pieces were more than just weapons…

"Guys! If I'm not totally off-base here, these weapons... they look like they were crafted by the First Ones," Maila announced, her eyes wide with realization.

"The First Ones, you say?" Iyexi mused, carefully picking up the armcannon. "Well, in that case, they might actually be of use to us."

Archer nodded, his hands running over the bow and arrows. He sensed the age and craftsmanship in the simple tools. Meanwhile, Finn took hold of the gloves, inspecting them with a quiet curiosity.

As for Maila, she found herself gravitating towards the trident, a sense of familiarity washing over her. Kazari, on the other hand,

chose the tanto and its sheath, a certain fondness evident in her gaze.

"Well, regardless of where they came from, they're definitely going to give us a boost for shop class," Finn commented, breaking the momentary silence. "So, at least there's that, right? Right, Kazari? Uh, Kazari?"

They all turned to look at Kazari, who seemed to be in a sort of trance. Her gaze was fixated on a rock outside the ship's window, where an unusual, smoky blob was swirling around…

Later that night…

Alone in the quiet of her dorm room, Kazari found herself captivated by the aged sword she had claimed earlier. It had an undeniable charm, a feeling of history that was too intriguing to ignore. With the sword resting in her lap, Kazari leaned back in her chair, her sketchbook splayed open on her desk.

Her pencil danced across the page, guided by her hand as she poured her thoughts into a flurry of lines and shapes. But there was one shape, one image, that kept resurfacing in her mind. The smoky blob she had seen swirling around the rock.

"What is that thing I keep seeing?" she wondered aloud, her gaze flicking back and forth between her sword and her sketchbook. "What is it trying to show me?" As the night deepened, Kazari

found herself lost in her thoughts, her curiosity piqued by the mystery of the swirling smoke and the sword.

Flying Colors! Beach Day at Candila!!

Arc 3



The Shifting Paradigm

A few days had passed since the fiasco at Sealineas, the Squad and the Trio had needed a break from all the chaos of the past few days, and, as fate would have it, they had all passed their assignments with a flying colors, and thus, as celebration, this was a perfect occasion to have some fun at the beach.

Mount Candila Beach

Without a single solitary cloud in the sky, the sun's warm golden rays kissed the rose-gold sand as the waves of the cool ocean washed along the shoreline, complemented by the equally cool, gentle breeze. Iyexi, clad in a white one piece with green and purple frills, was quite observant, taking in the sights of the beach, digging a hand into the sand, the others, sans Kazari, were close behind her.

Finn nervously gazed at the ocean's waves as they moved back and forth. "Gods damn you, moms…" they muttered to themself, heart beating in their chest "Where are you, Kaz…"

Maila placed a hand on the magicat's shoulder with a gentle smile, "It's okay, Finn. We're right here," she said, assuringly, though it's debatable as to how much it actually helped.

In any case, Rose and Riley got work, setting up blankets, beach chairs and umbrellas. Maila's mermaid strength was a godsend when it came to carrying the large cooler. As for Finn, they don't like to interact with water more than necessary, but little did they realize, they were standing a little too close to the water, so when the waves washed under their feet, their immediate reaction was

to recoil, sprinting back into camp area. Finn, dropped to their knees, clutching their chest as their heart was beating so fast, it threatened to burst from their chest, showering everyone in blood and bones.

Archer and Iyexi were quick to run up to Finn, with Iyexi gently rubbing their back. “Finn, just keep looking at us! Okay?” she said, holding eye contact with the distressed magicat, who was now in a cold sweat, continuing to mutter, “Damn you, moms….”

Archer tapped on his chin, wracking his brain for a solution, and then, with a gasp, he placed a hand on Finn’s shoulder “How about a distraction? Did you know?” Archer began, “Apparently there was a lost runestone somewhere inside of the mountainside…”

“Oh! You mean the legend of the Fire Princess?”

All eyes turned towards the new voice. Kazari, clad in a red and black bikini top that accentuated her figure, along with matching shorts, approached the group. Her blood-red hair flowed in the wind, catching everyone's attention.

For Finn, it felt like the Gods were throwing them a lifeline. Without hesitation, they leaped to their feet, rushing toward their fellow magicat and enveloping her in a tight embrace, as if Kazari were their salvation. Kazari, caught off guard, quickly

reciprocated, teasingly saying, “Woah, there. Where’s the fire?” before breaking the hug.

“Sorry I’m late, I kinda overslept,” Kazari explained, rubbing the back of her head with a chuckle. She then noticed Finn’s tired appearance, heavy bags hung beneath their eyes like an albatross. “Damn, Finn, looks like you haven’t been getting much sleep either, huh?”

In response, Finn yawned and said, “Yeah, well, Mamadora and Momeow were bitching at each other at such ungodly hours. It doesn’t tend to bring about a good night’s rest. I had to bail and trek all the way to Juliet’s place at about 3 AM! I’M LITERALLY RUNNING ON 3 HOURS OF SLEEP!” Their frustration was evident in their raised voice.

Kazari flashed her million-dollar smile at Finn. “Welp, we’re here now. Let’s unwind and have some fun, okay?”

Finn gave a soft gentle smile and said, “Okay…”

Meanwhile at Brightmoon…

The healing magic of She-Ra could only do so much to help with a headache brought on by an all-night screaming match with Catra. After downing a tablet for good measure, Adora went into the meeting room to join Bow and Glimmer.

"Hey, Adora," Bow asked pensively, trying not to disrupt any peace. "How are you feeling?"

Adora slammed herself into a chair and said emphatically, "No!" before grabbing a piece of bread and stuffing it into her mouth, rubbing her temples. Glimmer absentmindedly summoned a Rubik's Cube's worth of nose candy, imported from the Kingdom of Snows, and sprinkled it into her tea.

"Well, Adora, you and Catra just need time to cool down. Ohren has been itching to train with you, so why don't you get ready to meet her at Liq Ollum?"

Adora perked up, suddenly remembering what she came in for. "Has anyone seen Finn?"

"Apparently, they and the others are at the beach. Quite frankly, I'd say they all earned it," said Bow, chipper as ever.

Adora slumped down in her chair.

"Well, shit...I hope Finn's going to be okay..."

Back at the beach...

Finn nursed a water bottle as they watched Kazari play volleyball. Kazari took a running start and spiked the ball as hard as she could, but an errent gust of wind knocked the ball off course, ricocheting off the side of the net and smacking Finn in the face. Kazari gasped and ran over to Finn, who was now rubbing their nose.

"Crap! Sorry, Finn. You good?!" Kazari asked, concerned.

Finn slowly recovered, telling their fellow magicat, "Yeah, I think so. Man, it's a good thing you weren't using your havok magic, I would've been fifty shades of fucked!"

Kazari chuckled and sat down next to Finn, studying the water bottle. "At least your aversion to water doesn't extend to staying hydrated. Speaking of which…" Kazari's voice calmed to the gentle lull, almost like a whisper, in tandem with her accent, sounded like a mother effortlessly calming her frightened child, "What's up of you and water?"

Finn sat up with a somber sigh. "You're my best friend, I guess I owe you that much. I try not to hate my moms, but they make it pretty hard, such as one instant. I was only nine years old, it was my moms' wedding anniversary, everyone else tagged along to Space Vegas, but instead of doing the halfway sensible thing like letting me stay with Madame Razz or something, I was dragged along. I was in the hotel room, just vibing, but apparently that was not good enough for Mamadora and Momeow, who decided to drag us all down to the pool…"

Kazari’s eyes furrowed. “Finn, did they….?”

Finn simply nodded and said, “Yep, those bitches grabbed me and yeeted me into the deepest end of the fucking pool!”

Kazari could only let out a quiet, “Jebuss Fuck…”

Finn continued.

“As I flailed around in the water, every time I tried to escape the water, Momeow would scratch me and the others. Maila didn’t know how to use her powers, so she tried to get Mermista, but she was busy pegging Seahawk. Eventually, after nearly drowning, Spinnerella and Netossa had to come and fish me out. I was never the same…”

Kazari nodded, deep in thought. "I understand... Finn, it's not your fault."

Maila's voice rang out, “Yo! Finn! Kick the ball back to us!”

Finn jumped up, their gaze fixed on the ball, and gave it a swift punt towards the group. However, they misjudged the strength behind their kick. The ball soared past the others, bouncing off the ground, and plunging into the water. The magicat's heart sank.

"Fuuuuck..." they muttered under their breath.

Kazari offered a reassuring look and placed a comforting hand on Finn's shoulder. "Don't worry, Finn. I'll take care of it."

But just as Kazari was about to step into the water, Finn reached out and placed a trembling hand on their friend's shoulder. "No, Kaz. I'm the one who kicked the ball, so I need to be the one to retrieve it," they insisted, a shiver running down their spine at the mere thought.

Kazari suggested, "How about we go in together?"

Without further discussion, the two magicats cautiously waded into the water. Finn's palms grew clammy as they stepped further into the cool depths. With a sigh, Kazari crouched down and lifted Finn onto her back, causing a deep blush to spread across Finn's face. With a single powerful leap, Kazari plunged into the ocean with a resounding splash.

Kazari's rigorous strength training paid off, as she effortlessly carried Finn while swimming. But as the two drew closer to the ball, a glimmer caught Kazari's attention in her peripheral vision. Something protruded from the sandy ocean floor. Retrieving the ball, she handed it to Finn and asked, "Finn, do you trust me? I want to try out a new move with my havoc!"

Finn nervously nodded. "I trust you, Kazari."

Kazari placed her palm on Finn's chest and channeled a surge of havoc through her arm. With a powerful burst of energy, she launched the magicat out of the water, gathering sand and seaweed in their wake before skidding onto the towels. Concerned, the others rushed over to check on them. Meanwhile, Kazari took a deep breath and dived back beneath the waves, swimming down to explore what lay beneath. With a swift pivot, Kazari planted her feet firmly on the sandy ocean floor and crouched down to examine the object protruding from the ground. It had a distinct trapezoidal shape, and its surface shimmered with a shimmering blend of iridescent green and purple hues. It was a strange crystal, roughly the size of a rubber eraser. As Kazari extended her hand towards the crystal, tiny arcs of electricity danced and flickered across its surface. Swiftly grabbing it between her index and middle fingers, Kazari propelled herself

upwards, emerging from the water with a graceful leap. She leisurely made her way back to shore, using her free hand to wring out the water from her hair.

Archer and Iyexi approached Kazari, their curiosity evident as they gazed at the crystal. Meanwhile, Maila gasped in awe and exclaimed, "Holy shit! I've read about that! Unless I'm mistaken, that's a havok crystal. It's rumored to possess the ability to channel havok magic!"

Kazari's interest was instantly piqued. "Is that so? Hey, aren't we working on an art project soon?"

Finn nodded silently, and a spark of inspiration ignited within Kazari's mind.

"Interesting!"

Later that night...

Kazari retrieved a notebook and eagerly examined the crystal, analyzing its intricate details. With a focused determination, she

began sketching and meticulously jotting down notes, immersing herself in the depths of her creativity.

But then, an unexpected interruption shattered her concentration.

"Huh?!" Kazari's eyes widened in surprise as she noticed the return of that strange distortion in the corner of her dorm room. Reacting swiftly, she leaped out of her seat, her heart pounding in her chest. The distorted blob began to take on a peculiar shape, but just as quickly as it had appeared, it vanished into thin air.

"Note to self, talk to Master Micah!"

Shadow of a Chance

For better or worse, Kazari was like the daughter Micah never had, especially since he couldn't be with his own flesh and blood. Kazari had a hankering for some training, but instead of the sensible knock on the door, she opted for a bold entrance, barging into Micah’s quarters at the crack of dawn.

“Jebuss Krist, Kazari, it’s too early! You do know doors exist, right?” the King Father grumbled. Kazari's response was to haul Micah out of bed, declaring, “C’mon, Master Micah. Today's a training day!”

“Yeah, but this early? I’m not exactly a spring chicken anymore!”

“Age is just a number, Master!” the magicat retorted with a wink.

A while later, Kazari strapped weights snugly to her limbs, deftly navigating the obstacle course with a grace that left Micah in awe. Sparks of havoc magic danced off the weights like a miniature fireworks show. Sweat poured down her body, drenching her grey shorts and sports bra, crimson hair flowing in the wind. Kazari’s heart hammered in her chest, her body aching in that satisfying, workout way. The havoc magic still prickled like glass in her muscles, but she rode the runner’s high to numb the discomfort.

“Alright, I’m getting the hang of this!!” Kazari's tenacity was admirable; every improvement, no matter how small, felt like a triumph. As she tackled the monkey bars, her muscles crackled with soft green arcs of electricity from the havoc magic.

On the sidelines, Micah, visibly jittery from too much coffee, beamed like a proud parent—albeit one on the verge of a caffeine crash. Just then, Castaspella arrived, hands laden with clothing and a large, ancient-looking leather-bound book.

“Hey, Micah, Kazari putting in her paces?”

“Oh…uh..hiya, Casta….it seems more like Kazari is p-putting me t-through my paces…how she managed to break into my home is beyond me….”

Casta, setting down the book, used her now free hand to place a magical sigil on Micah’s back to purge the excess caffeine.

Micah, letting out a sigh, gave his sister a grateful smile as Kazari somersaulted through the air, landing right in front of the younger sorceress.

“Yo! Casta, are you here to train with us?” Kazari asked.

With a dismissive wave, Casta replied with, “Nah, fam. But, I could actually use your opinion on something; the Fertility Festival

is tonight and since I’m performing, I wanna wear something special!” she unfurled two outfits with her magic, one was a purple and blue leotard with gold trim, the other was a white, purple and gold top and miniskirt. Neither attire left much to the imagination, as shown with Kazari’s cheeks burning as red as her hair.

With a mischievous giggle, Kazari remarked, "Pick either one, and I'd be thrilled!"

Micah recoiled, suppressing the urge to vomit.

"Kazari, I actually need to speak with Micah about something important, so why don't you go freshen up? I'm sure your friends are waiting for you."

With a nod, Kazari followed Casta's suggestion and dashed off to the shower, but not before something caught her eye—a glint from beneath Casta's bed. Having already pilfered several pairs of panties, she figured she might as well investigate.

Meanwhile, Castaspella paced around, clutching the book with uncertainty.

"Casta, what's all this about?" Micah inquired.

Casta glanced around to ensure Kazari was out of earshot before turning back to Micah. "It's about Kazari... I've been researching and stumbled upon this book!" She flipped it open and turned to a specific page, as if she had rehearsed this moment a thousand times. "It delves into the concept of reincarnation. According to this, if one sacrifices their own life to save another, their soul is granted a new life through reincarnation."

Micah regarded Casta with a puzzled expression. "But, Casta," he began, "what does this have to do with Kaz—oh no... OH NO! OH MY GODS!" Micah exclaimed, a sudden realization hitting him like a ton of bricks.

"It's her eyes, Micah... they're almost identical to hers..."

Micah took a deep breath, his heart pounding in his ears like that old drumset we had in the storage building years ago..

"Wait, Casta... Kazari might resemble her, but could she truly be her reincarnation?"

Micah and Castaspella were at a loss for words, but as they struggled to find some semblance of a solution, Ohren was just around the corner, eavesdropping, thinking to herself, *"I fucking knew it!"*

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